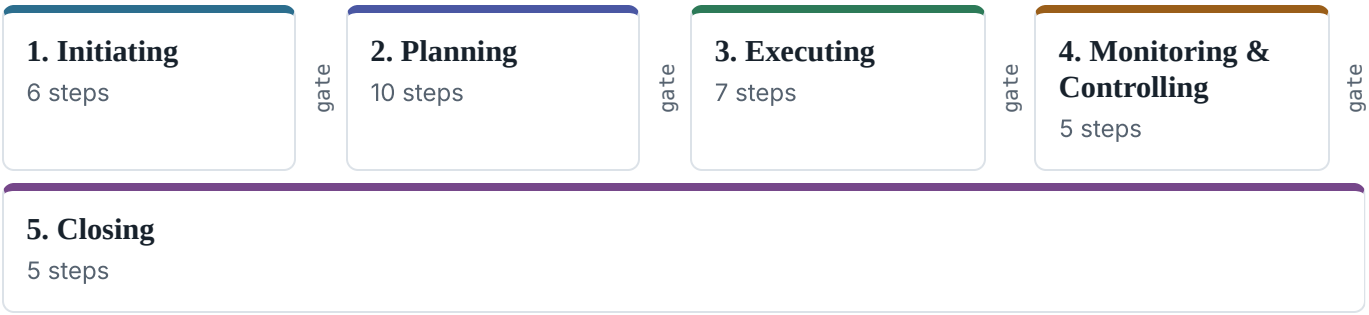
A PLAYBOOK FOR HYBRID, AGILE AND TECHNICAL PROJECTS

Project Manager in a Box

Every step of managing a project, from the first request to the final retrospective, with the inputs, outputs, owners and ready-to-use templates for each one.

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Latest version **on GitHub** License **CC BY-NC-SA 4.0**



33 steps · 30 templates · 1 project workbook with a live dashboard

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How to use this playbook

Use it in one of two ways. Follow it front to back as a project manager in a box, or dip into a single step to fill a gap in the way you already work.

Run a project with it

Start at Chapter 1 and work through each step in order. Every step tells you what to do, what you need, what you produce, where to keep it, who owns it and which template to use. Download the Project Workbook for your track first. Most templates are already built into it as tabs.

Fill a gap

Use the contents to jump straight to a step, such as change control or a status report. Each step stands on its own, and each template has its own guide in Appendix A.

CHOOSE YOUR TRACK

Every step has one shared core plus the guidance for your track. This copy shows the Hybrid track, with the Technical guidance. The web playbook switches between the tracks, and the other track has its own PDF.

AGILE TRACK

For projects that run entirely in sprints from a product backlog, with a named Product Owner, inside three limits set before work starts: a start and end date, a budget, and an out-of-scope statement. Inside those limits, what gets built is decided sprint by sprint.

- The solution will be shaped by user feedback as you go
- The date and budget are fixed, but there is no fixed specification
- One person can act as Product Owner, with the time and authority to order the backlog
- Little plan-driven work, such as long procurement, construction or regulatory phases, that must run on its own fixed plan

HYBRID TRACK

For projects that mix plan-driven work (fixed milestones, budgets, procurement, compliance) with iterative work (sprints, backlogs, frequent feedback). It is typical of business, operations, marketing and nonprofit programs, and of any project where some workstreams are predictable and others are not. Choose Hybrid over Agile when some of the work has to follow a fixed plan of its own.

- Fixed date or funding cycle, but the solution will change as you learn
- Mix of technical and non-technical workstreams
- Stakeholders need a milestone plan; the team prefers to work in sprints

TECHNICAL TRACK (IT + SECURITY)

For software, infrastructure, cloud, data and cybersecurity projects. It adds the gates technical work needs: architecture and security review, environments, test strategy, change advisory board (CAB) approval, cut-over and rollback, compliance evidence and handover to operations.

- Changes production systems, data or access
- Has security, privacy or regulatory obligations (e.g., PII, SOC 2, HIPAA, PCI DSS)
- Needs environments, deployments, cut-over or a rollback plan

Choose one approach, Agile or Hybrid, with the Track buttons at the top of the page. Then switch Technical on if the project changes production systems, data or access. On the Agile track the whole project runs in sprints, inside three limits set before it starts. On the Hybrid track, sprints run inside a plan with fixed milestones. The Technical track adds the gates and checks technical work needs, on either approach. The choice changes the text of the steps, the templates you are offered and the workbook you download. The two PDFs are printed with Technical on.

HOW EACH STEP IS LAID OUT

Each step has: **What it is**, **Why it matters**, **Inputs** (where to get them and who is responsible), **Outputs** (where they are kept and who is responsible), **Templates** (with download and guide), **How to do it**, **Track guidance** and **Done when**. Gates between phases are the formal checkpoints where the sponsor decides whether the project goes on.

Terms of art follow the PMBOK® Guide 8th Edition. PMI, PMBOK and PMP are registered marks of the Project Management Institute, Inc. This playbook is independent and is not affiliated with or endorsed by PMI.

Tailoring: Small, Medium, Large

Scale the process to the project. Pick a size in Step 1.4 and use this table to decide how much rigor each area needs. Record what you skip in Template T04.

AREA	SMALL	MEDIUM	LARGE
Typical profile	< 3 months, < 5 people, one team, low risk	3–9 months, 5–20 people, a few teams or one vendor	> 9 months, multiple teams or vendors, regulated or high risk
Charter	One-page charter, approved by email	Full charter, sponsor sign-off	Full charter + business case, steering-committee approval
Schedule	Milestone list + task board	WBS + Gantt with dependencies	Integrated master schedule with critical path and baselines
Risk	Top-5 risks in the RAID log	Scored RAID log, reviewed bi-weekly	Risk management plan, quantitative analysis, weekly review
Change control	PM + sponsor approve by email	Change request form + change log	Formal CCB, impact analysis required
Reporting	Weekly email update	Weekly status report + dashboard	Weekly status + monthly steering pack + gate reviews
Closing	30-minute retro + handover note	Retro, closeout report, transition sign-off	Full closeout, impact report, contract closure, audit archive

Roles

The ‘Responsible’ columns in every step use these roles. On a small project one person may hold several.

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO
Sponsor	Senior leader who owns the business case, funds the project, removes blockers and makes go/no-go calls at each gate.
Project Manager (PM)	Leads the project end to end: plans, coordinates, tracks, reports and protects scope, schedule, budget and quality.
Product Owner (PO)	Owns the backlog and its priority; speaks for users and decides what ‘done’ means for each feature. Common on Hybrid and Technical work.
Business Analyst (BA)	Elicits and documents requirements, maps processes and checks that the solution meets business needs.
Technical Lead	Owns the solution design, technical estimates, engineering quality and technical risk.
Security Lead	Owns security and privacy requirements, threat models, control evidence and sign-off for go-live (Technical track).
Functional Managers	Line managers who supply people to the project and agree to their availability.
Finance Partner	Validates estimates, releases funds, tracks actuals against the budget.
Procurement / Vendor Manager	Runs sourcing, contracts and vendor performance.
Change Control Board (CCB) / Change Advisory Board (CAB)	The group that approves changes to the baseline (CCB) or to production systems (CAB).
Delivery Team	The people who build, test and deliver the work.
Operations / Support Owner	Receives the finished product and runs it after go-live.

Project repository

Every output has a home. Set up this folder structure (in SharePoint, Google Drive, Confluence or a shared drive) on day one. The ‘Where it is kept’ column in every step refers to it.

FOLDER / FILE	CONTENTS
`00-Admin`	Charter, approvals, gate decisions, contacts
`01-Initiating`	Intake, business case, stakeholder register, approach worksheet
`02-Planning`	Requirements, scope, WBS and schedule, budget, plans (risk, comms, quality, sourcing)
`03-Executing`	Meeting notes, deliverables, test evidence, vendor documents
`04-Monitoring`	Status reports, change requests, RAID log snapshots, dashboards
`05-Closing`	Acceptance, transition, lessons learned, closeout and impact reports
`Project-Workbook.xlsx`	The live tracker: schedule, WBS dictionary, activities, requirements, backlog and sprints, RAID, budget, changes, decisions, acceptance, environment, dashboard

The Project Workbook

A fill-in-ready Excel tracker that runs the project alongside this playbook. There is one for each track. Fill in the Setup tab, add your work and risks, and the Dashboard and Status Report build themselves.

Blank workbook

22 tabs: Dashboard, Status Report, Setup, Schedule (WBS + Gantt), WBS Dictionary, Activity List, Requirements, Acceptance, RAID, Budget, Stakeholders, RACI, Comms, Changes, Decisions, Lessons, Environment, Backlog, Sprint Backlog and Sprint Log, plus a Start Here guide and editable dropdown lists. Backlog, Sprint Backlog and Sprint Log are for projects that run sprints.

Download XLSX

Worked example: Project Beacon

The same workbook filled in for a fictional nonprofit portal project, as a finished project, closed out on June 22, 2026. Use it to see what good looks like before you start your own.

Download XLSX

WHAT THE DASHBOARD TELLS YOU

- **Overall health**: the worst of the schedule, budget and risk ratings, using thresholds you set in Setup. You can override it.
- **Insights**: one auto-written sentence per area (schedule, budget, risk, change, scope, stakeholders) that you can paste straight into an update.
- **Next milestones and top five risks**, ranked automatically, plus charts and indicative earned value (SPI and CPI).

Files: 03-Project-Workbook/Project-Workbook.xlsx; 05-Examples/Project-Workbook-EXAMPLE-Project-Beacon.xlsx

CHAPTER 1 · 6 STEPS

Initiating

Decide whether the project should exist, and authorize it.

Initiating turns an idea or request into an authorized project. The goal is not a detailed plan. It is shared agreement on why the work matters, what success looks like, who is involved and how the work will broadly be delivered. Most failed projects can be traced back to a skipped or rushed Initiating phase: unclear goals, a missing sponsor or stakeholders who never agreed on scope.

Exit gate Initiation gate: the sponsor approves the charter, the PM is named, and funding for planning is released.

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Initiate Project or Phase; Identify Stakeholders (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

1.1 Capture the request and build the business case

1.2 Define goals and success criteria

1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders

1.4 Choose the delivery approach and tailor the playbook

1.5 Draft and approve the project charter

1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff

1.1 Capture the request and build the business case

WHAT IT IS

Turn the incoming request into a short, structured description of the problem, the opportunity, the options and the expected value. This is the business case: the argument that the project is worth doing at all.

WHY IT MATTERS

It stops projects that should never start, and it gives every later decision (scope, budget, trade-offs) something to anchor to. When people argue about scope later, the business case decides.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Request, idea or mandate	Email, intake form, strategy document or leadership meeting	Requester / Sponsor
Strategic goals or OKRs	Annual plan, strategy deck, OKR tracker	Sponsor / Leadership
Historical data and lessons from similar projects	PMO lessons library, past closeout reports	PMO / PM
Rough cost and benefit figures	Finance partner, vendor quotes, operational metrics	Finance Partner

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Intake & Business Case (approved or rejected)	Repository: 01-Initiating	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)
Go/no-go decision	Decision Log (workbook) and 00-Admin	Sponsor

TEMPLATES

T01 Project Intake & Business Case Download DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T01-Project-Intake-Business-Case.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Meet the requester and ask the ‘5 Ws’: what, why, who benefits, when and where.
2. Ask three stakeholders from different areas to describe the problem, then combine their answers into one problem statement.
3. Quantify the cost of doing nothing and the expected benefit.
4. Compare at least two options, including doing nothing, and recommend one.
5. Present to the sponsor and record the decision.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Show which parts of the value can be delivered early (e.g., a pilot or MVP) and which require a fixed-date launch. That shapes the hybrid approach in Step 1.4.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Add an early view of the technical options (build, buy, configure, SaaS), the systems affected, data sensitivity (public, internal, confidential, regulated) and any obvious security or compliance triggers.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Problem and benefits are quantified
- ✓ Options compared
- ✓ Sponsor decision recorded

1.2 Define goals and success criteria

WHAT IT IS

Write measurable goals (SMART goals or OKRs) and the criteria the sponsor will use to judge the project a success, covering both project success (on time, on budget, in scope) and product success (adoption, savings, risk reduced).

WHY IT MATTERS

Measurable goals make trade-offs objective and keep everyone aiming at the same target. Without them, 'done' becomes a matter of opinion and closeout becomes a negotiation.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Approved business case	01-Initiating	Sponsor
Organizational OKRs and KPIs	Strategy or OKR tracker	Leadership
Baseline metrics (today's numbers)	Operational reports, analytics, finance	Business owner / BA

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Goals and success criteria	Charter section 2 and the workbook Setup tab	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)

TEMPLATES

T02 Project Charter Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T02-Project-Charter.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Draft 2–4 goals using SMART (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound).
2. For each goal, record the baseline value, the target value and the data source.
3. Separate project success criteria from product or benefit success criteria.
4. Agree with the sponsor how and when the benefits will be measured. Some benefits arrive after closeout.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Add iteration-level goals (e.g., ‘pilot used by 20 volunteers by week 6’) as well as the end-of-project targets.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include non-functional targets: availability (e.g., 99.9%), performance, recovery time objective (RTO) and recovery point objective (RPO), and security outcomes (e.g., ‘MFA enforced for 100% of admin accounts’).

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every goal has a baseline, a target and a data source
- ✓ Sponsor agrees how success will be measured

1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders

WHAT IT IS

List everyone who can affect, or is affected by, the project. Assess their power, their interest and their current versus desired level of support.

WHY IT MATTERS

Stakeholders who are missed become late requirements, blockers or opponents. Early analysis tells you where to spend your relationship time.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Business case and charter draft	01-Initiating	PM
Organization charts	HR system / intranet	Functional managers
Sponsor and team knowledge	Interviews	Sponsor / PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Stakeholder Register with power/interest grid	Workbook: Stakeholders tab	PM
Environment Log started (insights about the wider environment around the project)	Workbook: Environment tab	PM

TEMPLATES

T03 Stakeholder Register & Power/Interest Grid Download XLSX

T28 Environment Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T03-Stakeholder-Register-Power-Interest-Grid.xlsx; 02-Templates/T28-Environment-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Brainstorm stakeholders with the sponsor and work through each group: users, managers, IT, finance, legal, vendors, regulators and partners.
2. Interview key stakeholders: priorities, concerns, preferred role, preferred communication.
3. Score Power and Interest 1–5 and place each person on the grid.
4. Plan an engagement action for anyone whose current support is below the level you need.
5. Start the Environment Log (T28) and note what is happening in the environment around the project that you should be aware of, such as a reorganization, a funding cycle, a regulatory date, or an initiative being taken up by other project teams that may influence or inspire this project. Project value does not exist in a vacuum. This log is for insights, not risks.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Identify the Product Owner early. In hybrid work that person makes the day-to-day priority calls.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include the Security, Privacy, Infrastructure and Operations owners, the Change Advisory Board (CAB), and any auditor or compliance contact.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Register complete
- ✓ Every high-power stakeholder has an engagement action
- ✓ Product Owner identified
- ✓ Environment Log started

1.4 Choose the delivery approach and tailor the playbook

WHAT IT IS

Decide how each workstream will be delivered (predictive, agile or hybrid) and how much of this playbook the project needs (Small, Medium or Large).

WHY IT MATTERS

The approach drives everything that follows: how you plan, report and handle change. Tailoring keeps the process proportionate, because too much process slows small projects down and too little sinks large ones.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Business case and goals	01-Initiating	PM
Organizational standards or PMO methodology	PMO / intranet	PMO
Team experience and constraints	Functional managers, Tech Lead	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Approach & Tailoring Worksheet	Repository: 01-Initiating	PM

TEMPLATES

T04 Delivery Approach & Tailoring Worksheet Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T04-Delivery-Approach-Tailoring-Worksheet.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Score each workstream on the suitability questions in T04 (requirement stability, feedback availability, cost of change, regulation and so on).
2. Choose an approach per workstream. One project can mix them.
3. Pick the project size using the tailoring table in ‘How to use this playbook’.
4. Record what you will skip or simplify and why.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Typical pattern: plan-driven governance (milestones, budget, gates) wrapped around agile delivery (sprints, backlog). Make the link explicit, for example ‘Milestone M3 = end of Sprint 4’.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Regulated or production-impacting work usually keeps formal gates (architecture review, security review, CAB) even when the build happens in sprints.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Approach chosen for each workstream
- ✓ Size and tailoring decisions recorded

1.5 Draft and approve the project charter

WHAT IT IS

Write the charter: the short document that formally authorizes the project, names the PM and sets the high-level scope, goals, milestones, budget, risks and governance.

WHY IT MATTERS

The charter gives the PM authority and gives everyone a single reference point. Under PMI’s approach it is the formal start of the project.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Business case, goals, stakeholder register, approach worksheet	01-Initiating	PM
High-level budget and funding source	Finance Partner	Finance Partner / Sponsor
Known constraints and assumptions	Sponsor, SMEs	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Signed Project Charter	Repository: 00-Admin; summary in the workbook Setup tab	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)

TEMPLATES

T02 Project Charter Download DOCX Example DOCX

T10 RACI Matrix Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T02-Project-Charter.docx; 02-Templates/T10-RACI-Matrix.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Fill in T02 using the earlier outputs. Don't rewrite what is already approved.
2. Write an explicit out-of-scope list.
3. Name the PM and their decision rights (e.g., can approve changes under 5 days or $5,000).
4. Review the draft with key stakeholders, resolve comments, then get the sponsor's signature.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Describe scope as outcomes plus a prioritized feature list rather than a fixed specification, and state how the backlog may change within the fixed date and budget.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Add the systems in scope, data classification, the required review gates (architecture, security, CAB) and the target environments.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Charter signed
- ✓ PM authority stated
- ✓ Out-of-scope list agreed

1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff

WHAT IT IS

Run a short gate review to confirm that Initiating is complete, then hold a kickoff meeting with the core team and key stakeholders to launch Planning.

WHY IT MATTERS

The gate makes sure the project is ready to move on. The kickoff builds shared understanding and momentum, and gives the team a chance to raise concerns early, when changes are still cheap.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Signed charter, stakeholder register	00-Admin, workbook	PM
Team availability	Functional managers	Functional managers

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Gate decision	Decision Log	Sponsor
Kickoff notes and action items	03-Executing/Meetings; actions in the workbook	PM

TEMPLATES

T05 Kickoff Meeting Kit Download DOCX

T18 Meeting Agenda & Minutes Download DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T05-Kickoff-Meeting-Kit.docx; 02-Templates/T18-Meeting-Agenda-Minutes.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Run the gate checklist: charter signed, sponsor engaged, funding confirmed for Planning.

2. Send the kickoff pre-read 48 hours ahead.
3. At kickoff, cover the why (sponsor), scope, milestones, roles (RACI), ways of working and next steps.
4. Send notes and actions within 24 hours.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Agree the team's working agreement at kickoff: sprint length, ceremonies and how milestone reporting will draw on sprint data.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Confirm access, tools and environments needed in the first two weeks (repositories, ticketing, cloud accounts, test data).

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Gate passed
- ✓ Kickoff held
- ✓ Actions logged

CHAPTER 2 · 10 STEPS

Planning

Work out how the work will get done, and set the baselines you will measure against.

Planning turns the charter into an integrated plan: what will be delivered (scope), when (schedule), for how much (budget), by whom (resources), with what risks, how people will be kept informed and how quality will be assured. The output is a set of baselines, the approved versions of scope, schedule and cost that progress is measured against. In hybrid work, plan the milestones in detail and keep the detailed backlog progressive (rolling-wave planning).

Exit gate Planning gate: the sponsor approves the integrated plan and baselines; the team commits to the schedule.

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Integrate and Align Project Plans; Plan Sourcing Strategy; Plan Scope Management; Elicit and Analyze Requirements; Define Scope; Develop Scope Structure; Plan Schedule Management; Develop Schedule; Plan Financial Management; Estimate Costs; Develop Budget; Plan Stakeholder Engagement; Plan Communications Management; Plan Resource Management; Estimate Resources; Plan Risk Management; Identify Risks; Perform Risk Analysis; Plan Risk Responses (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements

2.2 Define scope and build the work breakdown structure (WBS)

2.3 Build the schedule and milestones

2.4 Estimate costs and set the budget

2.5 Plan resources, roles and the RACI

2.6 Plan risk management: identify, analyze and plan responses

2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement

2.8 Plan quality and acceptance

2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement

2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate

2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements

WHAT IT IS

Find out from stakeholders what the solution must do (functional requirements) and how well it must do it (non-functional requirements). Record them in the Requirements Register. Requirements say what is needed; the work that builds them is tracked separately, as backlog items.

WHY IT MATTERS

Requirements are the bridge between the business goal and the deliverables. Most rework comes from requirements that were missing, vague or never agreed.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Charter, goals, stakeholder register	00-Admin, workbook	PM
Current process documents, user feedback, support tickets	Business owners, service desk	BA / PO
Policies and regulations	Legal, Compliance, Security	Compliance / Security Lead

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Requirements Register	Workbook: Requirements tab	BA / Product Owner
Product Backlog (if the project runs sprints)	Workbook: Backlog tab (or the team's backlog tool)	Product Owner

TEMPLATES

T06 Requirements Register Download XLSX

T25 Backlog Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T06-Requirements-Register.xlsx; 02-Templates/T25-Backlog.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose methods: interviews, workshops, observation, surveys, document review, prototyping.
2. Write each requirement as a user story (‘As a [type of user], I need [capability] so that [benefit]’) or a clear ‘shall’ statement, with acceptance criteria. The story describes the value the requirement promises.
3. Prioritize with MoSCoW together with the sponsor and the PO.
4. Trace each requirement to a goal, so anything that doesn’t serve a goal is challenged.
5. Have a named person approve each requirement before it is built, and record who approved it. Later, record who accepted it as delivered.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Fully specify the Musts for the first release. Break each requirement down into backlog items (T25), the work that delivers it, link each item to its requirement, and keep later items as epics to refine before each sprint (backlog refinement).

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Capture non-functional requirements explicitly: security, privacy, accessibility (WCAG 2.2 AA), performance, availability, logging, data retention and integration interfaces.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Musts have acceptance criteria
- ✓ Priorities agreed with the PO and sponsor
- ✓ NFRs captured
- ✓ Every Must has a named approver

2.2 Define scope and build the work breakdown structure (WBS)

WHAT IT IS

Turn the requirements into a scope statement (deliverables, acceptance criteria, exclusions) and break the deliverables down into work packages small enough to estimate and assign.

WHY IT MATTERS

The WBS is the backbone of the plan: the schedule, budget, RACI and risk register all hang off it. If work isn’t in the WBS, it isn’t in scope.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Requirements register	Workbook: Requirements	BA / PO
Charter scope and exclusions	00-Admin	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Scope Statement (scope baseline)	Repository: 02-Planning	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)
WBS	Workbook: Schedule tab (WBS IDs)	PM with the team
WBS Dictionary	Workbook: WBS Dictionary tab	PM with the team

TEMPLATES

T07 Scope Statement Download DOCX

T08 WBS & Schedule (Gantt) Download XLSX

T29 WBS Dictionary Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T07-Scope-Statement.docx; 02-Templates/T08-WBS-Schedule-Gantt.xlsx; 02-Templates/T29-WBS-Dictionary.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Write the scope statement: deliverables, acceptance criteria, exclusions, constraints, assumptions.
2. Run a WBS workshop with the people who will do the work. Decompose deliverables, not activities.
3. Stop decomposing when a work package can be estimated and owned by one person (about 1–10 days).
4. Number the items (1.0, 1.1, 1.1.1). Describe each work package in the WBS Dictionary (T29): what it delivers, its acceptance criteria and who accepts it.
5. Give each requirement in the Requirements Register (T06) the WBS ID of the work that delivers it.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

For agile workstreams, the WBS stops at epic or release level, and the backlog holds the detail. Requirements built in sprints point to that branch, not to one sprint.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include the work people often forget: environments, CI/CD pipeline, data migration, security testing, documentation, runbooks, training, cut-over and hypercare.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Scope statement signed
- ✓ WBS covers 100% of the scope
- ✓ Each work package has an owner

2.3 Build the schedule and milestones

WHAT IT IS

Sequence the work packages, estimate their durations, assign owners, identify dependencies and the critical path, and set milestone dates.

WHY IT MATTERS

The schedule turns scope into a commitment and shows which tasks have no room to slip (the critical path), so you know where to focus.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
WBS	Workbook: Schedule	PM
Resource availability and calendars	Functional managers, team	Functional managers
Estimates from the people doing the work	Estimating sessions	Delivery team / Tech Lead

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Project Schedule with milestones (schedule baseline)	Workbook: Schedule tab	PM
Activity List	Workbook: Activity List tab	PM, with the work package owners

TEMPLATES

T08 WBS & Schedule (Gantt) Download XLSX

T30 Activity List Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T08-WBS-Schedule-Gantt.xlsx; 02-Templates/T30-Activity-List.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. List the activities for each work package in the Activity List (T30): what has to be done, by whom and by when. Keep the Schedule at work-package level.
2. Ask the people doing the work for estimates. Break large tasks down and question their assumptions.
3. Use three-point estimates for uncertain work: (Optimistic + 4×Most likely + Pessimistic) ÷ 6 (the PERT method).
4. Enter the dependencies, then identify the critical path (the longest chain of dependent tasks).
5. Calculate float, also called slack: the number of days a task can slip without delaying the next task (free float) or the project finish (total float). Tasks on the critical path have no total float, so any slip moves the end date; track them most closely and mention them by name in status updates. Tasks off the path have float you can use when balancing resources. Recheck after every schedule change, because the critical path can move.
6. Add milestones where success can be tested, budget is committed or stakeholders need an update.
7. Add schedule contingency for the top risks and copy the approved dates into the Baseline columns.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Show sprints as recurring blocks on the Gantt and tie each milestone to a sprint review. Report sprint velocity next to milestone status.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Schedule review gates (architecture, security, CAB) and change freeze windows explicitly. They are fixed points that development work has to fit around.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Dependencies entered
- ✓ Critical path known
- ✓ Baseline saved
- ✓ Team commits to the dates

2.4 Estimate costs and set the budget

WHAT IT IS

Estimate the cost of every work package (labor, vendors, software, hardware, travel), add reserves and aggregate them into a time-phased budget (cost baseline).

WHY IT MATTERS

Funding approval depends on a credible estimate, and you can't control costs without a baseline to compare actual spend against.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
WBS and schedule	Workbook	PM
Labor rates and cost policies	Finance / HR	Finance Partner
Vendor quotes and license prices	Procurement, vendors	Procurement

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Budget and cost baseline	Workbook: Budget tab	PM (owner), Finance Partner (validator)

TEMPLATES

T09 Budget & Cost Tracker Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T09-Budget-Cost-Tracker.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Estimate bottom-up from the WBS: hours × rate plus non-labor costs.
2. Add a contingency reserve for identified risks and get management to agree a reserve for unknowns.
3. Phase the spend by month to match the schedule.
4. Have the Finance Partner validate it, then get the sponsor’s approval.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Agile workstreams are often funded by team capacity (team cost per sprint × number of sprints). Show that alongside the fixed-cost items.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include cloud consumption, license tiers, security tools, penetration testing, extra environments, and ongoing run costs after go-live (total cost of ownership).

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Budget validated by Finance
- ✓ Reserves shown separately
- ✓ Baseline approved

2.5 Plan resources, roles and the RACI

WHAT IT IS

Decide who you need, when and for how much of their time, and make clear who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted and Informed for each deliverable and decision.

WHY IT MATTERS

Unclear ownership is one of the most common causes of delay. A RACI turns ‘I thought you were doing it’ into an agreed fact.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
WBS and schedule	Workbook	PM
Staff availability and skills	Functional managers	Functional managers

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
RACI matrix	Workbook: RACI tab	PM
Resource commitments	Email or written agreement in 00-Admin	Functional managers

TEMPLATES

T10 RACI Matrix Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T10-RACI-Matrix.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. List the roles needed and the percentage of each person's time, by month.
2. Plan people at about 60 to 80% of their available project time, after subtracting meetings and leave (a common focus factor in agile capacity planning; a rule of thumb, not a standard). Support work and surprises take the rest, and waiting and delays grow sharply as a team nears full load, so a plan that fills everyone's week leaves no room to recover. If the plan needs more than people can give, change it now: move work, add people or cut scope. Cross-train so that no task depends on one person, and plan around known leave.
3. Get managers to commit those people in writing.
4. Build the RACI with exactly one Accountable per row.
5. Review it with the team and resolve any disputes over who owns what.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Spell out how the PM, PO and Scrum Master/Team Lead roles fit together. Who owns the milestone plan, and who owns the backlog?

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Assign named owners for the architecture, security, data, environments, releases and on-call support.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every deliverable has one A
- ✓ Resource commitments in writing

2.6 Plan risk management: identify, analyze and plan responses

WHAT IT IS

Find the risks to the project, score their probability and impact, and decide a response for each significant one. Record assumptions and dependencies at the same time.

WHY IT MATTERS

Risks you plan for are cheaper than surprises. A visible risk log also builds sponsor confidence and justifies the contingency reserves.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Charter, scope, schedule, budget	Workbook / 02-Planning	PM
Lessons from past projects	PMO lessons library	PMO
Expert input	Risk workshop with the team and SMEs	Team / SMEs

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
RAID Log	Workbook: RAID tab	PM (owner); each item has a named owner

TEMPLATES

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Run a risk workshop. Go category by category: scope, schedule, cost, people, technology, vendors, compliance, change adoption.
2. Write each risk as ‘Because of <cause>, <event> may occur, leading to <impact>’.
3. Before scoring, agree what the numbers mean on this project. A scale that suits a three-month internal project will mislead a nine-month one. Five levels is a common choice, not a requirement. The example scale below is for a Medium project. Write your own limits in days and money, keep them with the RAID log, and use them every time so everyone scores the same way.

4. Score probability and impact from 1 to 5. Anything scoring 12 or more is Red and 6–11 is Amber.
5. Choose a response (avoid, mitigate, transfer, accept) with an owner and a due date.
6. Copy the assumptions from the scope statement and the external dependencies into the same log.

EXAMPLE RISK SCALE FOR A MEDIUM PROJECT

SCORE	PROBABILITY	IMPACT
1	Would surprise the team	Absorbed within a normal week
2	Could happen, but not expected	A few days' slip, or a small cost the team can cover
3	About as likely as not	About a week's slip, or a cost the sponsor should hear about
4	More likely than not	Puts a milestone or the contingency reserve at risk
5	Expected to happen	Puts the project's goal or go-live at risk

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Review the risks at every sprint review. The demos often reveal new ones.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Run a threat model (e.g., STRIDE) for new systems and record security risks in the RAID log with the Security Lead as owner. Include vendor and third-party risk.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Top risks scored
- ✓ Every Red/Amber risk has an owner and response
- ✓ Assumptions logged

2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement

WHAT IT IS

Decide who needs what information, when, in what format and from whom. Plan how to move each key stakeholder from their current to their desired level of engagement.

WHY IT MATTERS

Many project failures are communication failures. A plan makes communication routine instead of reactive and builds trust with stakeholders.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Stakeholder register	Workbook: Stakeholders	PM
Stakeholder preferences	Stakeholder interviews	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Communication Plan	Workbook: Comms tab	PM
Recurring meetings on the calendar	Team calendar	PM

TEMPLATES

T12 Communication Plan Download XLSX

T03 Stakeholder Register & Power/Interest Grid Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T12-Communication-Plan.xlsx; 02-Templates/T03-Stakeholder-Register-Power-Interest-Grid.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Create one row per audience: sponsor, steering committee, team, end users, IT operations and so on.
2. Set the purpose, content, channel, frequency and owner for each.
3. Book recurring meetings now: status, steering and team ceremonies.
4. Add engagement actions for resistant or unaware stakeholders.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Invite stakeholders to sprint reviews. A live demo often does more than a written status report.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Plan release notes, maintenance-window notices, CAB submissions and incident communications.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every key stakeholder has a communication row
- ✓ Recurring meetings booked

2.8 Plan quality and acceptance

WHAT IT IS

Define the quality standards, the review and test activities, and the criteria and process for accepting each deliverable.

WHY IT MATTERS

Quality is meeting requirements and stakeholder expectations. Agreeing in advance how it will be judged avoids arguments over acceptance at the end.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Requirements and acceptance criteria	Workbook: Requirements	BA / PO
Organizational and industry standards	PMO, Compliance, Security	Quality / Compliance

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Quality & Acceptance Plan (incl. Definition of Done and test strategy)	Repository: 02-Planning	PM / Tech Lead
Definition of Done logged as a decision	Workbook: Decisions tab	PM
Acceptance Log set up	Workbook: Acceptance tab	PM / PO

TEMPLATES

T13 Quality & Acceptance Plan Download DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

T23 Acceptance Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T13-Quality-Acceptance-Plan.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx; 02-Templates/T23-Acceptance-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. List the standards that apply.
2. For each deliverable, define how its quality will be checked and who accepts it.
3. Write the Definition of Done with the team. Record it as a decision in the Decision Log (T17) with a version and date, and log every later change the same way, so the team can see how the standard moved.
4. Set up the Acceptance Log (T23): list each deliverable that will need acceptance, who accepts it and what evidence they will expect.
5. Schedule the quality activities in the plan (reviews, tests, audits).

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Use a Definition of Done for sprint work and formal acceptance criteria for milestone deliverables.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Write a test strategy covering unit, integration, system, UAT, performance, accessibility and security testing (SAST/DAST, vulnerability scans, penetration test), plus the entry and exit criteria for each.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Acceptance criteria for every deliverable
- ✓ Definition of Done agreed and logged as a decision
- ✓ Acceptance Log set up
- ✓ Test strategy approved (Technical track)

2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement

WHAT IT IS

Decide what to make versus buy, then plan how vendors will be selected, contracted and managed. Write a statement of work (SOW) for each purchase.

WHY IT MATTERS

Vendor lead times and contract terms often decide the schedule. A clear SOW protects scope, quality and payment.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Scope, WBS, budget	02-Planning, workbook	PM
Procurement policies and approved vendor list	Procurement	Procurement

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Statement(s) of Work	Repository: 02-Planning/Procurement	PM (author), Procurement (owner)
Vendor selection decision	Decision Log	Sponsor / Procurement

TEMPLATES

T14 Statement of Work (SOW) Download DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T14-Statement-of-Work-SOW.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make-or-buy analysis for each major component.
2. Write the SOW: deliverables, acceptance, timeline, payment milestones, security terms.
3. Run the selection (RFQ or RFP), score the vendors against agreed criteria and record the decision.
4. Add vendor milestones and dependencies to the schedule and RAID log.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

For vendors working in sprints, contract for capacity plus outcome-based milestones rather than a fixed specification.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include a vendor security assessment (e.g., SOC 2 Type II report review), data processing agreement, SLAs, data residency and exit/return-of-data terms.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ SOW reviewed by Procurement and Legal
- ✓ Vendor dates in the schedule

2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate

WHAT IT IS

Bring all the plans together into a consistent whole, check that scope, schedule, cost and resources agree with each other, and get approval for the baselines.

WHY IT MATTERS

The parts of a plan can each look fine but contradict each other, for example a schedule that assumes people the budget doesn't fund. Integration catches this before execution starts.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
All planning outputs (Steps 2.1–2.9)	02-Planning, workbook	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Approved project management plan and baselines	Repository: 02-Planning; baselines frozen in the workbook	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)
Planning gate decision	Decision Log	Sponsor

TEMPLATES

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

T15 Status Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx; 02-Templates/T15-Status-Report.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Cross-check: every WBS item has an owner (RACI), dates (schedule) and cost (budget).
2. Confirm the risk reserves cover the top risks.
3. Present the plan to the sponsor or steering committee for approval.
4. Freeze the baselines. From now on, changes go through change control (Step 4.2).

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Approve the milestone plan and the release roadmap. The detailed backlog stays flexible within them.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Get architecture and security design approval at this gate, or schedule them as explicit early milestones.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Baselines approved
- ✓ Gate decision logged
- ✓ Change control active

CHAPTER 3 · 7 STEPS

Executing

Lead the team and do the work defined in the plan.

Executing is where most of the time and money goes. The PM's job shifts from planning to leading: getting resources in place, keeping the team focused, removing blockers, assuring quality, managing vendors and keeping stakeholders engaged. Executing and Monitoring & Controlling run at the same time, so treat Chapter 4 as the control loop around this chapter.

Exit gate No formal gate. Execution moves into Closing when every deliverable has been accepted (Step 4.4).

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Manage Project Execution; Manage Quality Assurance; Manage Project Knowledge; Manage Stakeholder Engagement; Manage Communications; Acquire Resources; Lead the Team; Implement Risk Responses (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

3.1 Acquire and onboard the team

3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence

3.3 Assure quality

3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate

3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues

3.6 Manage vendors and contracts

3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions

3.1 Acquire and onboard the team

WHAT IT IS

Confirm the people on the project, onboard them (context, access, tools, working agreement) and build the team's working relationships.

WHY IT MATTERS

A team that understands the goal and has what it needs on day one delivers faster. Missing access and unclear expectations cost weeks.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Resource commitments, RACI	00-Admin, workbook	PM / Functional managers
Onboarding needs (access, tools, training)	Tech Lead, IT	Tech Lead

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Team roster and working agreement	Workbook: Setup tab; 03-Executing	PM
Access and tooling confirmed	Ticket references in the RAID log or Decision Log	Tech Lead / IT

TEMPLATES

T05 Kickoff Meeting Kit Download DOCX

T10 RACI Matrix Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T05-Kickoff-Meeting-Kit.docx; 02-Templates/T10-RACI-Matrix.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Hold short one-to-ones: experience, goals, how they like to work, how you can support them.
2. Write a team working agreement: hours, response times, tools, decision rules, escalation path.
3. Request access and equipment in advance and track it as a dependency.
4. Revisit the RACI with the full team.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Set up the sprint ceremonies (planning, daily stand-up, review, retrospective) and how milestone reporting will draw on sprint data.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Grant least-privilege access, set up the repositories, branching strategy, CI/CD and environments, and arrange any security awareness or secure-coding training required.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Everyone has access and tools
- ✓ Working agreement published

3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence

WHAT IT IS

Run the day-to-day rhythm that turns the plan into deliverables: task assignment, stand-ups, sprints or work-package check-ins, removing blockers and keeping the workbook up to date.

WHY IT MATTERS

A steady cadence makes progress visible and surfaces blockers while they are still small.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Schedule and backlog	Workbook: Schedule and Backlog tabs; backlog tool	PM / PO
Approved plan and RACI	02-Planning	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Deliverables (work products)	Repository: 03-Executing or the team's tools	Delivery team
Updated Activity List and Schedule (% complete, status)	Workbook: Activity List and Schedule tabs	PM (update), task owners (input)
Sprint Backlog and Sprint Log (if the project runs sprints)	Workbook: Sprint Backlog and Sprint Log tabs	Delivery team (plan), PM (check)

TEMPLATES

- T08 WBS & Schedule (Gantt) Download XLSX
- T30 Activity List Download XLSX
- T18 Meeting Agenda & Minutes Download DOCX
- T25 Backlog Download XLSX
- T26 Sprint Backlog Download XLSX
- T27 Sprint Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T08-WBS-Schedule-Gantt.xlsx; 02-Templates/T30-Activity-List.xlsx; 02-Templates/T18-Meeting-Agenda-Minutes.docx; 02-Templates/T25-Backlog.xlsx; 02-Templates/T26-Sprint-Backlog.xlsx; 02-Templates/T27-Sprint-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Hold a short daily or twice-weekly check-in: progress, plan for the day, blockers.
2. Each week, review progress with the task owners, then update the % complete and status in the workbook: in the Activity List for work packages that have activities, and in the Schedule for the rest.
3. Clear blockers within 24–48 hours or escalate them.
4. Protect the team from unplanned work. Send new requests through change control.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Sprint planning pulls from the prioritized backlog. Before each sprint, agree a one-sentence sprint goal; plan to 60 to 80% of the team's available hours, after subtracting meetings and leave; pick backlog items (T25) in priority order that fit and copy them into the Sprint Backlog (T26), which is cleared and rebuilt from empty at every planning session, each with an owner and any dependency named; confirm the Definition of Done everyone will use, in its current logged version (for example reviewed, tested, documented and accepted by the product owner); name the top risks for the sprint and who watches them; and book the sprint review and retrospective. After the review, record the result in the Sprint Log (T27): work planned and completed (items that met the Definition of Done), velocity, carry-over items and the retrospective headline. Record the Product Owner's accept or reject decisions in the Acceptance Log (T23), and return unfinished or rejected items to the Backlog. The PM keeps the milestone view current and manages dependencies between agile and plan-driven workstreams. Appendix B has the details.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Use pull requests with peer review, automated builds and tests, and track technical debt explicitly as backlog items.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Cadence running
- ✓ Workbook updated weekly
- ✓ Blockers resolved or escalated

3.3 Assure quality

WHAT IT IS

Carry out the quality activities in the plan (reviews, tests, audits) and improve the process when defects or rework show up.

WHY IT MATTERS

Finding defects early is far cheaper than finding them at acceptance or in production.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Quality & Acceptance Plan	02-Planning	PM / Tech Lead
Deliverables in progress	03-Executing	Delivery team

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Review and test results, defect log	03-Executing/Quality; defects in the RAID log or test tool	Tech Lead / QA

TEMPLATES

T13 Quality & Acceptance Plan Download DOCX

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T13-Quality-Acceptance-Plan.docx; 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Run the planned peer reviews and tests and record the results.
2. Run a short quality audit at least once per phase: are we following our own plan?
3. Look for patterns in defects and fix the cause, not just the defect.
4. Report the quality metrics in the status report (defects open, pass rate).

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Check every increment against the Definition of Done at the sprint review. Run a pilot or beta release to test with real users before the full launch.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Run SAST/DAST and dependency scanning in the pipeline, fix critical and high vulnerabilities before release, and keep the test evidence for audit.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Planned quality activities completed
- ✓ Defect trends reported

3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate

WHAT IT IS

Carry out the communication plan: status updates, steering meetings, demos and engagement actions. Adjust them as stakeholder needs change.

WHY IT MATTERS

Stakeholders who feel informed and heard support the project. Surprises destroy trust faster than bad news does.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Communication plan, stakeholder register	Workbook: Comms, Stakeholders	PM
Performance data	Workbook: Dashboard	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Status reports and meeting minutes	04-Monitoring/Status; 03-Executing/Meetings	PM
Updated stakeholder register	Workbook: Stakeholders	PM

TEMPLATES

T15 Status Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

T18 Meeting Agenda & Minutes Download DOCX

T12 Communication Plan Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T15-Status-Report.docx; 02-Templates/T18-Meeting-Agenda-Minutes.docx; 02-Templates/T12-Communication-Plan.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Send status updates on the agreed day, in the same format every time.
2. Deliver bad news early, with a plan and a request for what you need.
3. Follow up on engagement actions for resistant or unaware stakeholders.
4. Ask key stakeholders every month: 'Is this update giving you what you need?'

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Use sprint reviews and demos as the main way to engage stakeholders. Status reports summarize the trend across sprints.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Publish maintenance and release notices, and coordinate with the service desk so support is ready for user questions.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Communications sent on schedule
- ✓ Engagement gaps narrowing

3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues

WHAT IT IS

Carry out the planned risk responses when their triggers occur, and manage issues (problems that have already happened) through to resolution.

WHY IT MATTERS

A risk plan only has value if it is acted on. Issues left open grow and become schedule or budget overruns.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
RAID Log	Workbook: RAID	PM / item owners

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Updated RAID Log (actions, status)	Workbook: RAID	Item owners (update), PM (check)
Escalations	Email or steering pack; recorded in the Decision Log	PM

TEMPLATES

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) Download XLSX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Review the Red and Amber items in every status meeting.
2. When a risk occurs, change its type to Issue and start the planned response.
3. Escalate any issue the team can't resolve within its authority: state the problem, its impact, the options, your recommendation and the decision needed by when.
4. Close items when they are resolved and note what worked.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Raise blockers at the daily stand-up and log them in the RAID log only if they last more than a day or affect a milestone.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Route security incidents through the organization's incident response process, not just the project RAID log.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ No Red item without an active response
- ✓ Escalations made within agreed thresholds

3.6 Manage vendors and contracts

WHAT IT IS

Manage vendor performance against the SOW: progress, quality, invoices, issues and relationships.

WHY IT MATTERS

Vendor slips are among the most common causes of delay. Active management catches them early, and documented performance protects you if disputes arise.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
SOWs and contracts	02-Planning/Procurement	Procurement
Vendor status reports and invoices	Vendor	Vendor / PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Vendor performance notes and accepted deliverables	03-Executing/Vendors	PM / Procurement

TEMPLATES

T14 Statement of Work (SOW) Download DOCX

T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T14-Statement-of-Work-SOW.docx; 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Hold regular vendor check-ins linked to the SOW milestones.
2. Approve invoices only against accepted deliverables.
3. Log vendor risks and issues in the RAID log.
4. Escalate contractual issues to Procurement early.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Include vendor staff in the sprint ceremonies so their work stays visible.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Check vendor access is least-privilege and time-limited, and that the security obligations in the contract are being met.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Vendor deliverables accepted before payment
- ✓ Vendor risks logged

3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions

WHAT IT IS

Record decisions, rationale and know-how as the project goes, so the team and future projects can use them.

WHY IT MATTERS

Decisions that aren't written down get revisited. Knowledge that isn't captured leaves with the people who hold it.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Meetings, workshops, conversations	Calendar, notes	PM / Team

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Decision Log	Workbook: Decisions	PM
Working lessons learned	Workbook: Lessons	PM / Team

TEMPLATES

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

T19 Retrospective & Lessons Learned Register Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx; 02-Templates/T19-Retrospective-Lessons-Learned-Register.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Log every significant decision within 24 hours, including the options considered and why one was chosen.
2. Capture lessons as they happen, not only at the end.
3. Keep documents in the standard repository structure.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Retrospectives produce lessons every sprint. Copy the reusable ones into the Lessons tab.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Keep architecture decision records (ADRs), runbooks and as-built documentation in the code repository or wiki.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Decision Log current
- ✓ Lessons captured during the project

CHAPTER 4 · 5 STEPS

Monitoring & Controlling

Measure progress against the plan, control change, and keep the project on track.

Monitoring & Controlling runs alongside Executing from the first day of execution until closing. It compares actual performance with the baselines, forecasts where the project is heading, controls changes and makes sure deliverables are accepted. The Project Workbook dashboard is designed to support this chapter: update the tabs every week and the insights and status numbers update automatically. If the project drifts off track, Appendix E suggests a first response for the most common causes.

Exit gate Ongoing. Phase or release gates use the same data. The project moves to Closing when all deliverables are accepted.

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Monitor and Control Project Performance; Assess and Implement Changes; Monitor and Control Scope; Validate Scope; Monitor and Control Schedule; Monitor and Control Finances; Monitor Stakeholder Engagement; Monitor Communications; Monitor and Control Resourcing; Monitor Risks (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality

4.2 Control changes

4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement

4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables

4.5 Report status and escalate

4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality

WHAT IT IS

Compare actual progress and spend with the baselines every week, calculate the variances and forecast the finish date and final cost.

WHY IT MATTERS

Small variances caught early are cheap to fix. Forecasts let the sponsor decide while there are still options.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Updated schedule, budget actuals, RAID log	Workbook	Task owners, Finance Partner
Baselines	Workbook (baseline columns)	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Performance metrics and RAG status	Workbook: Dashboard	PM

TEMPLATES

T08 WBS & Schedule (Gantt) Download XLSX

T09 Budget & Cost Tracker Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T08-WBS-Schedule-Gantt.xlsx; 02-Templates/T09-Budget-Cost-Tracker.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Every week: tasks updated, actuals entered, RAID log reviewed.
2. Check the dashboard: % complete vs planned, overdue tasks, budget variance, open Red risks.
3. Optional earned value check: Schedule Performance Index (SPI) = EV ÷ PV and Cost Performance Index (CPI) = EV ÷ AC. Values below 0.9 call for action.
4. Agree corrective actions for any variance outside the thresholds (e.g., more than 10% or more than 5 days).

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Track sprint velocity and the release burn-up alongside milestone status. A falling velocity is an early warning that a milestone is at risk.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Add delivery metrics where they are useful, such as deployment frequency, change failure rate, open critical vulnerabilities and test pass rate.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Dashboard current every week
- ✓ Variances explained with an action

4.2 Control changes

WHAT IT IS

Assess every proposed change to scope, schedule, budget or quality, decide on it through the agreed authority and update the baselines when a change is approved.

WHY IT MATTERS

Uncontrolled change (scope creep) is one of the main reasons projects miss their targets. Change control doesn't prevent change. It makes sure each change is deliberate.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Change request (on the Change Request Form, where the project uses one)	Any stakeholder	Requester
Baselines and the PM's authority limits	Workbook; charter	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Completed Change Request Form (where used)	04-Monitoring/Changes	Requester (raises), PM (impact analysis)
Change Log with decisions	Workbook: Changes	PM
Updated baselines and plans (if approved)	Workbook; 02-Planning	PM

TEMPLATES

T24 Change Request Form Download DOCX Example DOCX

T16 Change Request & Change Log Download XLSX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T24-Change-Request-Form.docx; 02-Templates/T16-Change-Request-Change-Log.xlsx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. On predictive projects, and on hybrid work that has a change review board or other approval process, raise the request on the Change Request Form (T24) and analyze its impact on scope, schedule, cost, risk, quality and resources.
2. Recommend approve, reject or defer, and submit the form to the approver or change board named in the charter. Name who it is being submitted to before you send it.
3. Record the decision on the form. Whether or not a form is used, log every change in the Change Log (T16). If approved, update the baselines and the affected plans.
4. Tell the affected stakeholders and the team.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Most agile teams do not use a change request form. The Product Owner handles changes through the product backlog, and re-prioritizing items (swapping items of similar size) is normal practice. Use the form only for hybrid work that has a change review board or other approval process, and for changes to milestones, budget or the overall scope. Log every change either way.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Changes to production also need CAB approval, which is separate from the project's change control. Include the rollback plan and the risk rating in the CAB request.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ No change made without a logged decision
- ✓ Baselines reflect approved changes

4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement

WHAT IT IS

Check that risk responses are working, identify new risks, track issues and check that stakeholder engagement is moving in the right direction.

WHY IT MATTERS

Risks and stakeholders change throughout a project, so a register that isn't reviewed soon goes stale.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
RAID log, stakeholder register, Environment Log	Workbook	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Updated RAID log, stakeholder register and Environment Log	Workbook	PM / item owners

TEMPLATES

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) Download XLSX

T03 Stakeholder Register & Power/Interest Grid Download XLSX

T28 Environment Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx; 02-Templates/T03-Stakeholder-Register-Power-Interest-Grid.xlsx; 02-Templates/T28-Environment-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Review the risks every week (Red and Amber) and the full list every month.
2. Ask at every status meeting: ‘What new risks do we see?’
3. Review the Environment Log (T28) every two weeks. Look up from the project, add new insights about the environment around it and close entries that no longer matter. Risks do not belong in this log.
4. Check whether each response is reducing the score; if not, change the response.
5. Re-score stakeholder engagement each month and adjust the actions.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Use the sprint retrospective and sprint review to spot new risks and stakeholder concerns.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Track vulnerability findings, audit observations and vendor security issues through to closure.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ RAID log reviewed every week
- ✓ Environment Log reviewed every two weeks
- ✓ Stakeholder engagement re-scored every month

4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables

WHAT IT IS

Get formal acceptance of each completed deliverable from the person named in the RACI, against the acceptance criteria agreed in Planning.

WHY IT MATTERS

Formal acceptance is what lets the project close. Without it, deliverables can be disputed after the team has moved on.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Completed and quality-checked deliverables	03-Executing	Delivery team
Acceptance criteria	Quality & Acceptance Plan; Requirements	PM / PO

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Accepted deliverables and sign-off records	05-Closing/Acceptance	PM (records), Accepting stakeholder (signs)
Acceptance Log, kept current	Workbook: Acceptance tab	PM (records), Accepting stakeholder (accepts)

TEMPLATES

- T23 Acceptance Log Download XLSX
- T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off Download DOCX Example DOCX
- T06 Requirements Register Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T23-Acceptance-Log.xlsx; 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off.docx; 02-Templates/T06-Requirements-Register.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Show or test each deliverable against its acceptance criteria.
2. Record acceptance in writing and in the Acceptance Log (T23): the item or deliverable (with its WBS ID), the evidence, who accepted it and the date. Email is fine if the charter allows it.
3. Log rejected items with the reasons and a plan to fix them.
4. Check the Requirements Register (T06). The register marks a requirement ‘Accepted’ by itself once its named acceptor has accepted everything that delivers it: all of its items, or its work package. If anyone else accepted any of it, the acceptor decides on the whole requirement first, and the PM records that decision in the Acceptance Log.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

The PO accepts or rejects items at the sprint review, and each decision goes in the Acceptance Log (T23) with the sprint number. An accepted item leaves the Backlog; a rejected or unfinished item returns to it. The sponsor accepts milestone deliverables at gate reviews.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Get UAT sign-off, security sign-off (penetration test findings fixed or formally accepted) and operational readiness sign-off.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every deliverable accepted or has a remediation plan
- ✓ Acceptance Log current

4.5 Report status and escalate

WHAT IT IS

Produce the regular status report and dashboard, run steering meetings and escalate decisions that are above the PM’s authority.

WHY IT MATTERS

Leaders can only support what they can see. Consistent reporting builds trust and gets decisions made quickly.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Dashboard metrics	Workbook: Dashboard	PM
RAID log and Decision Log	Workbook	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Weekly status report	04-Monitoring/Status	PM
Steering committee pack (Medium/Large projects)	04-Monitoring/Steering	PM

TEMPLATES

T15 Status Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T15-Status-Report.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Update the workbook, then copy the dashboard numbers into the status report.
2. Set the overall RAG: Green = on track; Amber = at risk, recoverable by the team; Red = needs sponsor action.
3. Put decisions and help needed at the top.
4. Escalate using the format: issue, impact, options, recommendation, decision needed by.
5. If the project is off track, use Appendix E (Recovery plays by cause) to choose a first response before you escalate.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Show velocity and the release burn-up (from the Sprint Log, T27) next to milestone RAG so stakeholders see both views.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Add a short technical health section covering environments, the release pipeline, open critical vulnerabilities and incidents.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Report sent on schedule
- ✓ Escalations have decision dates

CHAPTER 5 · 5 STEPS

Closing

Hand over, learn, and formally finish.

Closing makes sure all the work is finished and accepted, the solution is handed over to the people who will run it, contracts are closed, lessons are captured and the team is released and recognized. Closing applies to each phase or release as well as to the end of the project. Skipping it leaves loose ends: unpaid invoices, unsupported systems, lost knowledge and a team that never got credit.

Exit gate Closure gate: the sponsor confirms the project is complete and approves the closeout report.

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Close Project or Phase (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations

5.2 Close contracts and finances

5.3 Run the retrospective and capture lessons learned

5.4 Write the closeout and impact report

5.5 Archive, release the team and celebrate

5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations

WHAT IT IS

Confirm that every deliverable is accepted, then formally hand the solution over to the business or operations owner with everything they need to run it.

WHY IT MATTERS

A project only creates value when its output is used and supported. Poor handover is a common reason benefits are never realized.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Acceptance records and the Acceptance Log	05-Closing/Acceptance; workbook	PM
Operational requirements (support model, training, documentation)	Operations owner	Operations / Support Owner

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Acceptance & Transition Sign-off	05-Closing	PM (author), Sponsor and Operations owner (sign)

TEMPLATES

T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off Download DOCX Example DOCX

T22 Go-Live Readiness & Security Checklist Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off.docx; 02-Templates/T22-Go-Live-Readiness-Security-Checklist.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Check that all acceptance records are complete, using the Acceptance Log (T23).
2. Hand over the documentation, training, access, support contacts and open defects.
3. Agree a hypercare period and its exit criteria (e.g., two weeks with no Severity 1 incidents).
4. Get the transition signed.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Train end users and run change-adoption activities, then track adoption metrics through hypercare.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Complete the go-live readiness checklist, run the cut-over and hypercare, hand over the runbooks and monitoring, and transfer admin access while removing project-only access.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Transition signed
- ✓ Hypercare exit criteria met

5.2 Close contracts and finances

WHAT IT IS

Confirm that vendors have delivered, settle the final invoices, close the purchase orders and the project cost codes, and release any unused reserve.

WHY IT MATTERS

Open contracts and cost codes create financial and legal exposure, and unused budget sitting in the project can’t be used elsewhere.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Contracts, SOWs, invoices	02-Planning/Procurement; Finance	Procurement / Finance Partner
Accepted vendor deliverables	03-Executing/Vendors	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Contract closure records and final financials	05-Closing/Financials; workbook Budget tab	Procurement, Finance Partner

TEMPLATES

T09 Budget & Cost Tracker Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T09-Budget-Cost-Tracker.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Confirm all vendor deliverables are accepted.
2. Pay the final invoices and close the purchase orders.
3. Record vendor performance for future sourcing decisions.
4. Reconcile the final budget against the baseline and close the cost codes.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Close capacity-based vendor agreements and reconcile them against the sprints actually delivered.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Make sure vendor access has been revoked, data has been returned or destroyed as the contract requires, and licenses are transferred to the operations owner.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ All POs closed
- ✓ Final cost reconciled
- ✓ Vendor access removed

5.3 Run the retrospective and capture lessons learned

WHAT IT IS

Hold a structured, blame-free review of what to start, stop and continue, and turn the lessons into concrete recommendations for future projects.

WHY IT MATTERS

Lessons not acted on just get repeated. A good retrospective makes the next project cheaper and less risky.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Lessons captured during the project	Workbook: Lessons	PM
Performance data (variances, change log, RAID history)	Workbook	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Lessons Learned Register	Workbook: Lessons; shared with the PMO library	PM

TEMPLATES

T19 Retrospective & Lessons Learned Register Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T19-Retrospective-Lessons-Learned-Register.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Invite the core team and key stakeholders, and make it a safe space.
2. Walk through the timeline and milestones to refresh memories.
3. Ask: what should we start, stop and continue doing?
4. Turn each lesson into a recommendation with an owner (e.g., update template T08).

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Combine the themes from the sprint retrospectives with the end-of-project review.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include post-incident reviews and deployment metrics, and feed improvements back into engineering standards.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Retrospective held
- ✓ Each lesson has a recommendation and an owner

5.4 Write the closeout and impact report

WHAT IT IS

Summarize what was delivered, how the project performed against its baselines, the benefits achieved, the lessons and the open items. Present the impact to the sponsor and stakeholders.

WHY IT MATTERS

It formally records the project's results, shows the value delivered and gives future teams a reference.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Baselines and final actuals	Workbook	PM
Success criteria and benefit measures	Charter; business owner	Sponsor / Business owner
Lessons Learned Register	Workbook: Lessons	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Closeout & Impact Report	05-Closing	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)

TEMPLATES

T20 Closeout & Impact Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T20-Closeout-Impact-Report.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Compare the final scope, schedule and cost with the baselines and explain the variances.
2. Report results against each success criterion, with data.
3. List open items and their new owners, and the plan for measuring later benefits.
4. Present to the sponsor and get approval to close.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Show the value delivered in increments over the life of the project, not only at the end.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include final architecture, security posture (residual risks accepted), operational metrics since go-live and the technical debt handed over.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Report approved by the sponsor
- ✓ Benefit measurement plan handed to the business owner

5.5 Archive, release the team and celebrate

WHAT IT IS

Archive the project records, release the people and resources, update the PMO records and recognize the team's contribution.

WHY IT MATTERS

Archives support audits and future projects, releasing resources quickly helps the rest of the organization, and recognition builds the goodwill your next project will need.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
All project records	Project repository	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Archived repository (read-only)	Organizational records system	PM / PMO
Team release notes and recognition	Email to managers; team event	PM

TEMPLATES

T20 Closeout & Impact Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T20-Closeout-Impact-Report.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Clean up and archive the repository using the retention rules.
2. Tell functional managers the release dates and give feedback on each person's contribution.
3. Celebrate: thank the team publicly, share the impact story and recognize individuals.
4. Close the project in the PMO portfolio.

TRACK GUIDANCE

HYBRID

Celebrate milestones throughout the project as well as at the end.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Archive the repositories, decommission temporary environments and confirm that project service accounts and credentials are revoked.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Archive complete
- ✓ Team released and recognized
- ✓ Project closed in the portfolio

Appendix A. Template library

Every template is an original, editable file with its usage guide built in. Templates marked ‘also in the workbook’ exist both as a standalone file and as a tab in the Project Workbook. Five Word templates (the charter, the status report, the change request form, the closeout report and the acceptance sign-off) also have a filled-in example from the fictional Project Beacon, in the 05-Examples folder.

T01 Project Intake & Business Case

Download DOCX

Captures a request in enough detail to decide whether it should become a project.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Complete sections 1–4 with the requester in a 30–45 minute conversation.
2. Quantify the problem: cost of doing nothing, volume affected, risk exposure.
3. List at least two options (including ‘do nothing’) and recommend one.
4. Have the Finance Partner check the cost and benefit numbers before the sponsor sees them.
5. Get a go/no-go decision from the sponsor and record it in section 8.

Used in: 1.1 Capture the request and build the business case

File: 02-Templates/T01-Project-Intake-Business-Case.docx

T02 Project Charter

Download DOCX

Example DOCX

Formally authorizes the project and gives the PM authority to use organizational resources.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Copy the problem, goals and benefits from the approved Intake (T01). Do not rewrite them from scratch.
2. Write in-scope and out-of-scope items as a bulleted list. Out-of-scope is the part that prevents scope creep.
3. List high-level milestones only (5–8). The detailed schedule comes in Planning.
4. Name the PM and state their authority level (budget, staffing, change approvals).
5. Circulate for comments, then get a recorded sign-off from the sponsor.

Used in: 1.2 Define goals and success criteria, 1.5 Draft and approve the project charter · also in the workbook (tab: Setup)

File: 02-Templates/T02-Project-Charter.docx

T03 Stakeholder Register & Power/Interest Grid

Download XLSX

Lists everyone affected by or able to affect the project, and plans how to engage each one.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Brainstorm names with the sponsor; ask each stakeholder ‘who else should I talk to?’
2. Score Power and Interest 1–5. The grid quadrant is calculated automatically.
3. Set Current vs Desired engagement (Unaware, Resistant, Neutral, Supportive, Leading).
4. Write one concrete engagement action for every gap between current and desired.
5. Review monthly. People change roles and their attitudes change.

Used in: 1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders, 2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement, 4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement · also in the workbook (tab: Stakeholders)

File: 02-Templates/T03-Stakeholder-Register-Power-Interest-Grid.xlsx

T04 Delivery Approach & Tailoring Worksheet

Download XLSX

Chooses the track for the project, Agile or Hybrid, decides whether the Technical track applies, and records which playbook steps to scale up or down.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Score each workstream on the eight suitability questions (1 = predictive, 5 = agile).
2. Agile: every workstream averages 3.5 or more, a Product Owner can be named, and the project can work inside three limits. Otherwise Hybrid.
3. Technical: yes if the project changes production systems, data or access, or has security, privacy or regulatory obligations.
4. Pick a size (Small/Medium/Large) using the tailoring table in the playbook.
5. Record every step you will skip or simplify, with the reason, so auditors and successors understand your choices.

Used in: 1.4 Choose the delivery approach and tailor the playbook

File: 02-Templates/T04-Delivery-Approach-Tailoring-Worksheet.xlsx

T05 Kickoff Meeting Kit

Download DOCX

Agenda, talking points and checklist for the project kickoff meeting.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Send the pre-read (charter summary) 48 hours before the meeting.
2. Have the sponsor open the meeting with the ‘why’. It gives the project credibility.
3. Walk through the scope, the milestones, the roles and how the team will work together.
4. Capture questions in the decision log or RAID log and send notes within 24 hours.

Used in: 1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff, 3.1 Acquire and onboard the team

File: 02-Templates/T05-Kickoff-Meeting-Kit.docx

T06 Requirements Register

Download XLSX

Captures what the solution must do and how well, as requirements with priority, acceptance criteria, an approver and an acceptor, and links to the work that delivers them.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write each requirement as a user story (‘As a [type of user], I need [capability] so that [benefit]’) or as a ‘shall’ statement. The story states the value the requirement promises. The work that builds it is tracked separately, as backlog items in the Backlog (T25).
2. Prioritize with MoSCoW (Must, Should, Could, Won’t this time).
3. Every Must needs testable acceptance criteria and a named approver before it is built.
4. Name one approver and one acceptor for each requirement. The approver approves it before it is built. The acceptor is accountable for accepting it as delivered, and is often the same person.
5. The register works out a delivery status for you from the other logs. For a requirement built in sprints: Not started, In backlog, In Sprint N (when a linked item is in the current sprint), the count of linked items accepted (for example 2 of 3), Ready for acceptance, and Accepted. For a requirement delivered by plan-driven work, with no backlog items, the status comes from the Schedule line for its WBS ID: Not started (0% complete), In progress (with the percentage) and Ready for acceptance (100%). Either way, if the requirement’s acceptor accepted everything that delivers it (all of its items, or its work package), the requirement becomes Accepted by itself. If other people accepted some of it, the status stays Ready for acceptance until the acceptor decides on the whole requirement and the PM records that decision as a Requirement-level row in the Acceptance Log (T23), so that one named person accepts the whole requirement. Accepted by and the date are then taken from that row.
6. Give each requirement the WBS ID of the work that delivers it: a work package for plan-driven work, or the branch that holds the sprint work for work built in sprints (not one sprint’s line, because items can move between sprints). Link it to its test case. Each backlog item in the Backlog (T25) names the requirement it delivers.

Used in: 2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements, 4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables · also in the workbook (tab: Requirements)

File: 02-Templates/T06-Requirements-Register.xlsx

T07 Scope Statement

Download DOCX

Defines the deliverables, acceptance criteria, exclusions, constraints and assumptions in detail.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Expand the charter scope into specific deliverables with acceptance criteria.
2. List exclusions explicitly, especially ‘nice to have’ items that were turned down.
3. Record constraints (date, budget, technology, regulation) and assumptions; copy the assumptions into the RAID log.
4. Get sign-off from the sponsor and the Product Owner. This becomes the scope baseline.

Used in: 2.2 Define scope and build the work breakdown structure (WBS)

File: 02-Templates/T07-Scope-Statement.docx

T08 WBS & Schedule (Gantt)

Download XLSX

Breaks the scope into work packages and schedules them with owners, dates, dependencies and progress.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Decompose the deliverables (not activities) until each work package fits in 1–10 working days.
2. Enter the start date and duration. The finish date and the Gantt bars are calculated for you.
3. Use the Predecessor column to record dependencies and to find the critical path.
4. Mark milestones with a duration of 0.
5. Once the plan is approved, copy the dates into the Baseline columns and leave them unchanged.
6. Put work built in sprints under one branch, with a line for each sprint as a time box. The detail lives in the Backlog (T25).
7. Describe each work package in the WBS Dictionary (T29). When a work package is accepted or rejected, the decision goes in the Acceptance Log (T23) with its WBS ID, and the Acceptance column shows the result.
8. List the activities inside each work package in the Activity List (T30), not in the Schedule. The Schedule then calculates the work package's % complete from them, and the Flag column shows "Check %" if a typed % or status disagrees.

Used in: 2.2 Define scope and build the work breakdown structure (WBS), 2.3 Build the schedule and milestones, 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence, 4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality · also in the workbook (tab: Schedule)

File: 02-Templates/T08-WBS-Schedule-Gantt.xlsx

T09 Budget & Cost Tracker

Download XLSX

Builds the cost estimate and tracks planned vs actual spend by category.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Estimate bottom-up from the WBS: labor (hours × rate) plus non-labor items.
2. Add a contingency reserve sized to the risk (typically 5–15%) and show it on its own line.
3. Enter actuals monthly from the finance system. Variance and percent spent are calculated for you.
4. Investigate any line more than 10% over its plan.

Used in: 2.4 Estimate costs and set the budget, 4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality, 5.2 Close contracts and finances · also in the workbook (tab: Budget)

File: 02-Templates/T09-Budget-Cost-Tracker.xlsx

T10 RACI Matrix

Download XLSX

Makes clear who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted and Informed for each deliverable or decision.

HOW TO USE IT

1. List the deliverables or decisions down the rows and the roles or people across the columns.
2. Exactly one A per row. The check column flags rows with no A or more than one.
3. Keep the number of C entries low. Each extra one slows decisions down.
4. Review the matrix with the team at kickoff and get explicit agreement on it.

Used in: 1.5 Draft and approve the project charter, 2.5 Plan resources, roles and the RACI, 3.1 Acquire and onboard the team · also in the workbook (tab: RACI)

File: 02-Templates/T10-RACI-Matrix.xlsx

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies)

Download XLSX

One register for everything that could, or already does, get in the way of delivery.

HOW TO USE IT

1. A risk is something that might happen. An issue is something that has happened. Move risks to issues when they occur.
2. Score Probability and Impact 1–5. The score (P×I) and RAG rating are calculated for you.
3. Every Red or Amber item needs an owner, a response (avoid, mitigate, transfer, accept) and a due date.
4. Review the top 10 items in every status meeting and close out stale entries.

Used in: 2.6 Plan risk management: identify, analyze and plan responses, 3.3 Assure quality, 3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues, 4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement · also in the workbook (tab: RAID)

File: 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx

T12 Communication Plan

Download XLSX

Defines who gets what information, how often, in which format and from whom.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Build one row per audience, not per message.
2. Ask stakeholders how they prefer to receive updates. Don’t assume.
3. Assign an owner to every communication and put recurring ones on the calendar right away.
4. Review the plan after each gate and whenever stakeholders change.

Used in: 2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement, 3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate · also in the workbook (tab: Comms)

File: 02-Templates/T12-Communication-Plan.xlsx

T13 Quality & Acceptance Plan

Download DOCX

States quality standards, review and test activities, and how each deliverable will be accepted.

HOW TO USE IT

1. List the standards that apply (internal policies, industry or regulatory standards).
2. For each deliverable, define the quality check (peer review, test, audit) and who approves it.
3. Define the Definition of Done for agile work, give it a version and date, and log it and every later change in the Decision Log (T17). Define the acceptance criteria for milestone deliverables.
4. Technical track: attach the test strategy (unit, integration, UAT, performance, security).

Used in: 2.8 Plan quality and acceptance, 3.3 Assure quality

File: 02-Templates/T13-Quality-Acceptance-Plan.docx

T14 Statement of Work (SOW)

Download DOCX

Describes the work a vendor will perform, its deliverables, timeline, acceptance and payment terms.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write deliverables as outcomes with acceptance criteria, not as hours of effort.
2. Tie payments to accepted deliverables or milestones wherever possible.
3. Include requirements for security, data handling and confidentiality.
4. Have Procurement and Legal review it before it goes to vendors.

Used in: 2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement, 3.6 Manage vendors and contracts

File: 02-Templates/T14-Statement-of-Work-SOW.docx

T15 Status Report

Download DOCX

Example DOCX

A one-page weekly update: overall RAG, progress, next steps, top risks and decisions needed.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Lead with the overall RAG rating and one sentence explaining why.
2. Report progress against milestones, not activity (‘Design approved’, not ‘worked on design’).
3. List decisions or help needed with an owner and a date. This is the most-read section.
4. Use the same format every week so readers can compare reports at a glance. The workbook dashboard supplies the numbers.

Used in: 2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate, 3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate, 4.5 Report status and escalate · also in the workbook (tab: Dashboard)

File: 02-Templates/T15-Status-Report.docx

T16 Change Request & Change Log

Download XLSX

Documents proposed changes to scope, schedule or budget, their impact and the approval decision.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Anyone can raise a change. Log every change here, whether or not a Change Request Form (T24) is used. The Change Request Form is for predictive projects and for hybrid work with a change review board or other approval process. Most agile projects do not use one, because the Product Owner handles changes through the product backlog.
2. The PM runs the impact analysis (scope, schedule, cost, risk, quality, resources) and notes the requirements or WBS IDs the change affects.
3. Bring it to the approver named in the charter or the CCB with a recommendation.
4. If approved, update the baselines and tell the affected stakeholders.
5. Rejected changes stay in the log. They show the decision was considered.

Used in: 4.2 Control changes · also in the workbook (tab: Changes)

File: 02-Templates/T16-Change-Request-Change-Log.xlsx

T17 Decision Log

Download XLSX

Records significant decisions, the options considered, who decided and why.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Log any decision that would be expensive to reverse or that someone may question later.
2. Record the options considered and the reasoning, not just the outcome.
3. Log the Definition of Done when it is agreed and again whenever it changes (version, date, what changed and why), so the team can see how the standard moved.
4. Link related change requests or RAID items.

Used in: 1.1 Capture the request and build the business case, 1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff, 2.8 Plan quality and acceptance, 2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement, 2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate, 3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues, 3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions, 4.2 Control changes, 4.5 Report status and escalate · also in the workbook (tab: Decisions)

File: 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

T18 Meeting Agenda & Minutes

Download DOCX

A standard agenda and minutes format that turns meetings into decisions and actions.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Send the agenda at least 24 hours ahead with the desired outcome of each item.
2. Record decisions, actions (owner and date) and new risks. Skip the play-by-play.
3. Send the minutes within 24 hours and move the actions into the workbook.

Used in: 1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff, 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence, 3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate

File: 02-Templates/T18-Meeting-Agenda-Minutes.docx

T19 Retrospective & Lessons Learned Register

Download XLSX

Captures what to start, stop and continue, and turns lessons into actions for future projects.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Run short retrospectives after each sprint or phase, not only at the end of the project.
2. Use the Start/Stop/Continue framing so the discussion stays safe and constructive.
3. Convert each lesson into a recommendation with an owner (e.g., update a template or standard).
4. Share the register with the PMO or a lessons library.

Used in: 3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions, 5.3 Run the retrospective and capture lessons learned · also in the workbook (tab: Lessons)

File: 02-Templates/T19-Retrospective-Lessons-Learned-Register.xlsx

T20 Closeout & Impact Report

Download DOCX

Example DOCX

Summarizes what was delivered, performance against baselines, benefits, lessons and open items.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Compare the final scope, schedule and cost to the baselines and explain the variances.
2. Report benefits against the success criteria in the charter, with data.
3. List open items and who now owns them.
4. Use the impact section (executive summary, results, what worked, next steps) as the sponsor briefing.

Used in: 5.4 Write the closeout and impact report, 5.5 Archive, release the team and celebrate

File: 02-Templates/T20-Closeout-Impact-Report.docx

T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off

Download DOCX Example DOCX

Records formal acceptance of deliverables and the handover to operations or the business owner.

HOW TO USE IT

1. List every deliverable with its acceptance evidence (test results, demo, inspection). Copy them from the Acceptance Log (T23).
2. Confirm the operations owner has the training, documentation, access and support model they need.
3. Agree a warranty or hypercare period and its exit criteria.
4. Have the sponsor and the receiving owner sign it.

Used in: 3.6 Manage vendors and contracts, 4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables, 5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations

File: 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off.docx

T22 Go-Live Readiness & Security Checklist

Download XLSX

Technical track: confirms that release, security, data, rollback and support criteria are met before production changes.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Start the checklist at least two weeks before the planned go-live.
2. Each item needs an owner, a status and evidence (a link or document).
3. Any ‘No’ on a critical item blocks go-live unless the sponsor and Security Lead record an exception.
4. Attach the completed checklist to the CAB request.

Used in: 5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations

File: 02-Templates/T22-Go-Live-Readiness-Security-Checklist.xlsx

T23 Acceptance Log

Download XLSX

Records every acceptance decision during the project, for backlog items, work packages and other deliverables: the evidence, who accepted or approved it, when, and the decision. Plan-driven and sprint work are accepted in the same log.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Add one row per acceptance decision. The PM keeps the log and records each decision. Choose the level: Item (a backlog item shown at a sprint review), Deliverable (a work package, milestone or release item in the WBS, accepted by the acceptor named in the WBS Dictionary, T29) or Requirement (the final decision by a requirement's named acceptor, needed only when someone else accepted its items or its work package).
2. For an item, record its ID and title, the one requirement it satisfies and the sprint number (an item that serves two requirements gets one row for each). For a deliverable, record its name and its WBS ID (one per row). For a requirement, record its ID.
3. Record the date and the evidence (test result, demo, inspection, document review).
4. Record the decision (Accepted or Rejected), who accepted or approved it and the date. An item with unmet conditions is not accepted: record it as Rejected, with the work still needed. A rejected item returns to the Backlog. A rejected work package stays in the Schedule until it is fixed and accepted. The next decision on either is a new row.
5. At the end of the project, use the log to complete the Acceptance & Transition Sign-off (T21).

Used in: 2.8 Plan quality and acceptance, 4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables · also in the workbook (tab: Acceptance)

File: 02-Templates/T23-Acceptance-Log.xlsx

T24 Change Request Form

Download DOCX

Example DOCX

A one-page form for proposing a change, analyzing its impact, recommending a decision and recording the approval. For predictive projects and for hybrid work with a change review board or other approval process.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Anyone can raise a change. Describe the change, why it is needed and what happens if it is not made.
2. The PM completes the impact analysis for scope, schedule, cost, risk, quality and resources.
3. Recommend approve, reject or defer, and submit the form to the approver or change board named in the charter. The form must say who it is submitted to.
4. Record the decision and the date. If approved, update the baselines, tell the affected stakeholders and add a row to the Change Log (T16).
5. Technical track: if production is affected, attach the rollback plan and the risk rating for the CAB, which approves separately.

Used in: 4.2 Control changes

File: 02-Templates/T24-Change-Request-Form.docx

T25 Backlog

Download XLSX

Lists the open work to be built in sprints, ranked and sized, with each item linked to the requirement it delivers. It changes constantly: items leave for a sprint, return, and are re-ranked.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Break each requirement (T06) down into the work that delivers it: a feature, task, fix, spike (a short, time-boxed investigation) or technical debt item. Link every item to its requirement. An item such as a bug fix may have no new requirement. The requirement says what is promised; the item says how it will be built.
2. Rank the items. The Product Owner owns the order and can re-rank at any time. The top of the list is detailed and ready; the bottom can stay rough.
3. Give each item a size in the team's own unit.
4. At sprint planning, pull the items for the next sprint into the Sprint Backlog (T26). Items that are not finished, or that are rejected at the sprint review, return here and are ranked again.
5. An accepted item leaves the Backlog. Its record is the Acceptance Log (T23).

Used in: 2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements, 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence · also in the workbook (tab: Backlog)

File: 02-Templates/T25-Backlog.xlsx

T26 Sprint Backlog

Download XLSX

Lists the backlog items the team commits to in the current sprint, with owners and progress. It is rebuilt from an empty sheet at every sprint planning session and holds nothing needed later.

HOW TO USE IT

1. At sprint planning, clear the sheet. Write the sprint number and the one-sentence sprint goal.
2. Pull items from the Backlog (T25) in rank order until the sprint is full, planning to 60 to 80% of the team's available time.
3. Give each item an owner and note any dependency.
4. Update the status as the sprint runs. Mark an item done only when it meets the Definition of Done.
5. At the sprint review, copy the totals into the Sprint Log (T27), record the Product Owner's decisions in the Acceptance Log (T23) and return unfinished or rejected items to the Backlog. Then the sheet is ready to clear for the next sprint.

Used in: 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence · also in the workbook (tab: Sprint Backlog)

File: 02-Templates/T26-Sprint-Backlog.xlsx

T27 Sprint Log

Download XLSX

Records the plan and result of each sprint, including sprints that deliver nothing: work planned and completed, velocity, carry-over items and the retrospective headline.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Add one row per sprint at sprint planning: the sprint’s line in the Schedule (its WBS ID, from which the dates are looked up), the goal and the work planned, in the team’s unit.
2. At the sprint review, copy in the work completed from the Sprint Backlog totals. Count only items that meet the Definition of Done. Acceptance is a separate decision, recorded in the Acceptance Log (T23). A sprint that completes nothing still gets a row.
3. Velocity and the running average are calculated, and the Dashboard draws the burn-up against total scope.
4. List the carry-over items (their IDs), the top risk for the sprint, any decisions needed and the headline from the retrospective, with a link to the Lessons Learned Register (T19).
5. Plan from the trend, not from one sprint: a falling velocity with stable scope is an early warning.

Used in: 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence · also in the workbook (tab: Sprint Log)

File: 02-Templates/T27-Sprint-Log.xlsx

T28 Environment Log

Download XLSX

Keeps the PM looking up from the project to the wider environment in which it is meant to deliver value. It records insights to be aware of. It is not a place to store risks.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Every few weeks, step back from the project and look at the environment around it: the organization, the market, regulation, technology, and other teams' work.
2. Log an insight when you notice it: what you learned, where it came from, a short category in your own words (for example, a reorganization, a strategy shift, a funding change, market or economic conditions, regulation, weather, or another team's initiative) and when it takes effect.
3. Note why it matters to the value the project is meant to deliver, so that you stay aware of it.
4. Keep it light. An entry needs no project resources to watch, and it does not belong in the RAID log unless it becomes a risk. Risks are managed through the risk process, not here.
5. Review the log every two weeks and close entries that no longer matter.

Used in: 1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders, 4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement · also in the workbook (tab: Environment)

File: 02-Templates/T28-Environment-Log.xlsx

T29 WBS Dictionary

Download XLSX

Describes each work package in the WBS: what it delivers, how it will be accepted and who accepts it. It shows the requirements that point to it and its acceptance result.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Add one row per work package, using its WBS ID from the Schedule (T08). The name is looked up, so it is typed only once.
2. Describe what the work package delivers, and anything that is in or out of it, so the owner and the team read it the same way.
3. Write its acceptance criteria and name one acceptor.
4. The requirements in the Requirements Register (T06) that point to this WBS ID are counted for you.
5. The number of its activities that are done, and its % complete, come from the Activity List (T30) and the Schedule.
6. When the work package is accepted or rejected, record the decision in the Acceptance Log (T23) with its WBS ID. The dictionary shows the result.
7. Work built in sprints needs one row for its branch, not one per backlog item. The Backlog (T25) holds the detail.

Used in: 2.2 Define scope and build the work breakdown structure (WBS) · also in the workbook (tab: WBS Dictionary)

File: 02-Templates/T29-WBS-Dictionary.xlsx

T30 Activity List

Download XLSX

Lists the activities inside each work package, with owners, dates and progress. The Schedule's % complete for a work package is calculated from its activities.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Add one row per activity, using the WBS ID of its work package from the Schedule (T08). Give it an ID (for example 4.1-A1), a short name, an owner, a start date and a due date.
2. Enter the effort, in hours or days. It is the activity's weight when the work package's % complete is worked out. A blank effort counts as 1.
3. Each week, get an update from each activity's owner, then enter the % complete and status. Done counts as 100%.
4. When an activity is done, the person who checks it (usually the work package owner) confirms it, and the PM enters their name under Verified by, with the date.
5. Watch the Flag column: Overdue, Blocked, or Outside work package dates (the activity's dates fall outside the work package's Schedule dates).
6. When every activity in a work package is done, the Schedule shows the work package as Ready for acceptance. Its acceptor accepts the work package as a whole, and the PM records the decision in the Acceptance Log (T23). Activities are not accepted one by one.
7. A work package with no activities works as before: type its % complete in the Schedule.

Used in: 2.3 Build the schedule and milestones, 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence · also in the workbook (tab: Activity List)

File: 02-Templates/T30-Activity-List.xlsx

Appendix B. Agile quick reference

Projects that run sprints do so inside a plan with fixed milestones. This appendix covers what a project manager needs to run that combination, on the Hybrid track or on a Technical project that works in sprints. It is not a course in Scrum or any other framework; the sources at the end go deeper.

B.1 The sprint cycle

A sprint is a fixed-length period, usually two to four weeks (Project Beacon uses two), in which the team turns the highest-priority backlog items into finished, usable work. The fixed length gives the team a rhythm, and it gives you a dependable unit for milestone planning. Five regular events keep the cycle running. The time limits below grow with sprint length: the first figure is for a two-week sprint and the second for a four-week sprint. For a three-week sprint, use the middle.

1. Sprint planning. The Product Owner brings the top-priority items. The team decides how much it can finish and agrees a sprint goal: one sentence on why this sprint matters. Output: the sprint goal and the sprint backlog (T26). Time limit: 4 hours (two-week sprint), 8 hours (four-week sprint).
2. Daily stand-up. A 15-minute check where the team compares progress with the sprint goal and names blockers. It is for the team, not a status report to the PM.
3. Backlog refinement. Ongoing work in which the Product Owner and team clarify, split and size upcoming items so they are ready for planning. Common guidance is to keep it to roughly a tenth of team capacity.
4. Sprint review. At the end of the sprint the team shows working results to the Product Owner and stakeholders. The Product Owner accepts or rejects each item that meets the Definition of Done, against its acceptance criteria, and records the decision in the Acceptance Log (T23). Unfinished and rejected items return to the backlog, and feedback goes into it. It doubles as your stakeholder demo and a checkpoint for the milestone plan. Afterwards, record the sprint's result in the Sprint Log (T27). Time limit: 2 hours (two-week sprint), 4 hours (four-week sprint).
5. Sprint retrospective. The team looks at how it worked, picks one or two changes to try next sprint, and records any lessons for the Lessons Learned Register (T19). Time limit: 1.5 hours (two-week sprint), 3 hours (four-week sprint).

B.2 Who does what

Use this rule of thumb: the PM owns when and how much money, the Product Owner owns what, and the team owns how.

- Product Owner: orders the backlog, explains each item, and accepts or rejects finished work.
- Delivery team: decides how many items fit in a sprint and how to build them. Nobody outside the team assigns work inside a sprint.
- Scrum Master or team lead: coaches the way of working and clears blockers. On a small project this may be the PM, but avoid combining the PM and Product Owner roles, because it removes the check between “what we want” and “what we can afford”.
- Project Manager: owns milestones, budget, risks, stakeholders and vendors, and reads sprint results into the milestone plan. The PM does not reorder the backlog or assign sprint work.
- Sponsor: accepts milestone deliverables at the gates.

B.3 Writing stories and backlog items

Write each requirement that users will see as a short user story: “As a [type of user], I need [capability] so that [benefit].” The story describes the value the requirement promises. Add acceptance criteria that say how anyone can tell the requirement is met. Check each story against six qualities, which agile teams remember as INVEST: it can be built Independently, it is open to Negotiation, it delivers Value, the team can Estimate it, it is Small enough to deliver in a sprint or two, and it is Testable.

Large stories are called epics. Split an epic into smaller stories before its work enters the backlog.

Requirements and backlog items are different things. A requirement is a specification: what the solution must do or achieve, with acceptance criteria and a named approver. Its user story describes the value it promises. It lives in the Requirements Register (T06). A backlog item is the work that delivers that promise, a piece of work or a capability to build in a sprint, and it lives in the Backlog (T25). Break each requirement down into one or more items and link each item to its requirement. One requirement may need several items, and an item such as a bug fix or technical debt may trace to no new requirement.

How an item moves. Every item starts as a requirement. The requirement, with its user story, goes in the Requirements Register (T06) and names its approver, its acceptor and the WBS ID of the branch that holds the sprint work. The requirement is then broken down into backlog items, the work that delivers it, and the items go in the Backlog (T25). The Product Owner ranks the Backlog and can re-rank it at any time. At sprint planning the team pulls items into the Sprint Backlog (T26), which holds one sprint only and is rebuilt from empty each time. At the sprint review, the Product Owner accepts or rejects each item that meets the Definition of Done, and the decision goes in the Acceptance Log (T23) with the sprint number. An accepted item leaves the Backlog. A rejected item, or one that was not finished, returns to the Backlog and is ranked again, so one item can pass through several sprints. A requirement is accepted

when every item that delivers it is accepted. If the requirement's named acceptor accepted all of its items, the Requirements Register marks it Accepted by itself. If different people accepted different items, the acceptor decides on the whole requirement and the PM records that decision in the Acceptance Log, so that one named person is accountable for the whole. The Requirements Register shows each requirement's status, from Not started to Accepted, with who accepted it and when, taken from the Backlog, the Sprint Backlog and the Acceptance Log.

Acceptance criteria and the Definition of Done are different. Acceptance criteria belong to one story or requirement ("a volunteer can cancel a shift up to 24 hours before it starts"). The Definition of Done is a checklist that applies to every item (reviewed, tested, documented). Meeting it is the team's own test of finished work. Acceptance is a separate decision by the Product Owner or approver. The Quality & Acceptance Plan (T13) records the Definition of Done, and the Decision Log (T17) records each change to it.

B.4 Story mapping

A story map arranges the backlog as a picture of the user's journey instead of a flat list.

1. Write the main activities a user performs, left to right, in the order they happen. This row is the backbone.
2. Under each activity, stack the stories that support it, with the most important at the top.
3. Draw horizontal lines across the map to slice it into releases. The top slice is the thinnest version that is still useful to a real user.

A map shows the whole product before the parts, gives the Product Owner and sponsor a shared picture, and makes it easy to explain what waits for a later release. Project Beacon's volunteer side looks like this:

```
Sign up      Find a shift    Book or cancel   Do the shift   Log hours       Get certificate
-------      ------------    --------------   ------------   ---------       ---------------
Account      Browse open     Book a shift     (offline)      Enter hours     Download PDF
with MFA     shifts          Cancel up to                    after a shift   with total hours
                             24h before
             Coordinators: create recurring shifts with capacity limits
- - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - -
Release 1 (MVP pilot, Mar 27): everything above this line (Sprints 1 to 3)
                                                                 Text reminders
                                                                 (deferred)
```

The donor side (recurring gifts, nightly CRM sync) forms a second backbone, planned for Sprints 4 and 5.

B.5 Planning releases and linking them to milestones

1. Size the backlog. Give each item a relative size (story points or small, medium, large). Relative sizing is quicker and, over many items, about as reliable as hour estimates.
2. Learn the team's velocity. Velocity is the amount of work a team finishes in one sprint, counted in whatever unit the team estimates in. If the team sizes work in story points, velocity is the story points completed per sprint. Count only items that are fully done and meet the Definition of Done: a nearly finished item adds nothing. Record it in the Sprint Log (T27). Before any sprint has finished, plan with a range and replace it with real numbers after the second or third sprint.
3. Work out what fits. Sprints available multiplied by the velocity range gives the scope the team can deliver by the date. Plan people at about 60 to 80% of their available project time, after subtracting meetings and leave (see the capacity guidance in the planning steps).
4. Place milestones at sprint ends. A milestone tied to a sprint review has real evidence behind it.
5. Re-forecast every sprint. When the date and the budget are fixed, scope is the variable. Use the MoSCoW lines (Must, Should, Could) to decide what moves when the forecast slips.

Use a burn-up chart to show progress. It plots two lines against time: total scope and work completed. The gap between them is the work left. When scope grows, the scope line rises and everyone can see it, which is why a burn-up is better than a burn-down for stakeholder reporting.

Velocity has two good uses. The team's recent average tells you how much work to plan into coming sprints, and the trend over several sprints shows whether the team is speeding up or is blocked. Treat a change as a prompt to ask why, not as a grade: a rising number can simply mean the estimates are growing. Do not compare velocity across teams, because each team's estimates are relative to its own work. Do not make it a target either, because pushing it up tends to inflate estimates instead of finishing more. A falling velocity alongside a stable scope line is an early warning that a milestone is at risk.

B.6 Keeping the plan-driven and agile halves in step

Watch for these common problems.

- Fixing milestone dates before anyone has sized the backlog.
- The PM reordering the backlog, which is the Product Owner's job.
- Raising a change request for ordinary reprioritization. Swapping items of similar size inside the backlog is normal. Changes to milestones, budget or overall scope go through change control.
- Skipping the retrospective when the schedule is tight. That is when it pays back most.
- Marking items done that do not meet the Definition of Done. Milestone reports then look healthier than the product is.
- Reporting velocity without scope. Show both, as a burn-up.

B.7 Project Beacon in practice

Sprint 2 (February 23 to March 6, 2026) delivered shift booking. Its goal, in one sentence: “A volunteer can see open shifts and book or cancel one.” The sprint backlog held the items for R-02 (book and cancel) and R-03 (recurring shifts with capacity limits), and the password reset item carried over from Sprint 1. Late in the sprint the work was about 80% complete, and the sprint review moved from March 6 to March 10. The same sprint carried the spike to test the CRM’s API limits (risk R-002). In that week’s status report, the PM reported the milestone view (the MVP pilot on March 27 on track, go-live still June 1 with one week of float used) and linked the sprint evidence to it, rather than reporting task activity.

B.8 Where to learn more

These sources are also listed in Appendix D.

- Schwaber, K. and Sutherland, J. (2020). The Scrum Guide. https://scrumguides.org
- Patton, J. (2014). User Story Mapping. O’Reilly Media.
- Wake, B. (2003). INVEST in Good Stories, and SMART Tasks. https://xp123.com/invest-in-good-stories-and-smart-tasks/
- Project Management Institute and Agile Alliance (2017). Agile Practice Guide.
- Beck, K. et al. (2001). Manifesto for Agile Software Development. https://agilemanifesto.org

Appendix C. Glossary

Short definitions in plain words, listed alphabetically. Each term appears in the playbook, the templates, the example workbook or Appendix B.

Acceptance criteria
The specific conditions an item must meet before the person accepting it agrees it is done.

Acceptance Log
A running record of every acceptance decision for backlog items, deliverables and requirements: the evidence, who accepted or approved it, the date, the sprint for an item, and the decision (Accepted or Rejected).

Activity list
The steps inside each work package, with owners, dates and progress. In the workbook it drives each work package's % complete.

Agile Project Manager (Agile PM)
The project manager on the Agile track. See the roles section for the definition.

Assumption
Something believed true for planning purposes but not yet confirmed. Record it in the RAID log so someone checks.

Backlog (product backlog)
The ordered list of everything that might be built, kept by the Product Owner. The top is detailed and ready; the bottom is rough.

Backlog item
A piece of work that delivers a requirement and is built in a sprint, such as a feature, task, fix or spike. Each item is linked to its requirement. An accepted item leaves the backlog; a rejected or unfinished one returns to it.

Baseline
The approved version of the scope, schedule or budget that you measure progress against. It changes only through change control.

Benefits realization
Confirming, after delivery, that the expected benefits actually appeared, with data.

Burn-up chart

A chart of total scope and completed work over time. The gap between the lines is the work remaining.

Business case

The argument for doing a project: the problem, the options, the costs and benefits, and the recommendation.

CAB (Change Advisory Board)

The group that approves changes to production systems before they go live.

CCB (Change Control Board)

The group that approves changes to a project's baseline.

Change request

A formal proposal to change the scope, schedule or budget, with its impact analysis and a decision.

Charter

The document that authorizes the project and gives the PM authority to use resources.

Contingency reserve

Money or time set aside for identified risks. Draw on it only through the agreed process.

CPI (Cost Performance Index)

Earned value divided by actual cost. Below 1.0 means the work is costing more than planned; above 1.0 means less.

Critical path

The longest chain of dependent tasks. A delay to any task on it delays the finish date.

Cut-over

The moment when users and data move from the old way of working to the new one.

DAST (dynamic application security testing)

Testing a running application from the outside for security weaknesses.

Definition of Done

A checklist that every backlog item must meet before the team calls it finished. It is not the same as acceptance, which is a separate decision by the Product Owner or approver.

Deliverable

Something the project produces that someone can inspect and accept.

Dependency

A relationship in which one task, or an outside event, must happen before another can start or finish.

Developers

The people on a Scrum team who build, test and deliver each increment.

Earned value

The budgeted value of the work actually completed. Used to compare progress with spending (see CPI and SPI).

Environment Log

A short record of insights about the wider environment in which the project is meant to deliver value, such as organizational changes, funding cycles, market or regulatory conditions, and other teams' initiatives. It keeps the PM aware of the bigger picture. It is not a risk register.

Epic

A large user story that must be split into smaller stories before its work can be built.

Feature

A capability users will recognize, such as "Shift booking". On the Agile track, features group requirements in the Requirements Register and the Acceptance Log.

Float (slack)

How long a task can slip without delaying the finish date. Tasks on the critical path have none.

Forecast (sprints left)

The scope remaining at the last sprint review divided by the average velocity, rounded up. It gives the forecast finish date.

Gantt chart

A bar chart of tasks against time, showing start, finish and dependencies.

Gate

A planned decision point where a sponsor or committee decides whether the project may continue to the next stage.

Hybrid delivery

Mixing plan-driven management (fixed milestones, budget, approvals) with iterative delivery (sprints and a backlog).

Hypercare
A short period after go-live when the project team stays close to fix problems quickly before handing over fully.

Increment
The working result of a sprint, usable and meeting the Definition of Done.

Issue
A problem that has already happened and needs action. A risk becomes an issue when it occurs.

Lessons learned
What the team learned that could improve future work, written as recommendations with an owner.

MFA (multi-factor authentication)
Signing in with two or more proofs of identity, such as a password and a code from a phone.

Milestone
A significant point in the plan, such as an approval or a delivery. It takes no time itself.

MoSCoW
A priority scheme: Must, Should, Could, Won’t this time.

MVP (minimum viable product)
The smallest version of a product that real users can use and give feedback on.

OKR (objectives and key results)
A goal-setting method that pairs an ambition with measurable results.

Out-of-scope statement
What the project will not include, however the backlog changes. One of the three limits on the Agile track.

PMO (project management office)
A group that sets project standards, supports project managers and often tracks the portfolio.

Product goal
The future state of the product that the backlog serves. The Product Owner is accountable for it.

Product Owner
The person who owns the backlog, decides its order and accepts or rejects finished work.

RACI

A matrix showing who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted and Informed for each deliverable or decision.

RAG (red, amber, green)

A traffic-light rating of status.

RAID log

One register of Risks, Assumptions, Issues and Dependencies.

Release

A set of finished work made available to users.

Release plan

The sprints between the start and end dates, with the releases, milestones and fixed events.

Requirement

A specification of what the solution must do or achieve, with acceptance criteria and a named approver. Its user story describes the value it promises; backlog items are the work that delivers it.

Retrospective

A team meeting to review how the work went and agree improvements.

Risk

An uncertain event that, if it happens, affects the project. Score it by probability and impact.

Rolling-wave planning

Planning near-term work in detail and later work at a higher level, adding detail as it gets closer.

RPO (recovery point objective)

How much recent data, measured in time, an organization can afford to lose after an outage.

RTO (recovery time objective)

How long a service can be down before the harm becomes unacceptable.

SAST (static application security testing)

Analyzing source code for security weaknesses without running it.

Scope creep

Growth in what the project must deliver without matching changes to time, budget or approval.

Scrum Master

The person who coaches a team in its way of working and removes blockers.

SLA (service level agreement)

A written commitment to a level of service, such as response times.

SOW (statement of work)

The document describing what a vendor will do, by when, to what standard and for what payment.

SPI (Schedule Performance Index)

Earned value divided by planned value. Below 1.0 means behind schedule.

Sprint

A fixed-length period in which a team completes a chosen set of backlog items.

Sprint backlog

The backlog items the team commits to finish in one sprint, chosen at sprint planning. It is rebuilt from empty for each sprint.

Sprint goal

One sentence that states the purpose of a sprint.

Sprint Log

A record of each sprint's goal, plan and result, including sprints that deliver nothing: work planned and completed, velocity, carry-over items and the retrospective headline.

SSO (single sign-on)

One login that gives access to several systems.

Stakeholder

Anyone affected by the project or able to affect it.

Story map

A picture of the user's journey with stories stacked beneath each step, sliced into releases.

Technical debt

The future cost of shortcuts taken in design or code. It is tracked as backlog work.

Threat model

A structured review of how a system could be attacked and which controls address each threat.

Three limits

The start and end date, the budget and the out-of-scope statement: the baselines on the Agile track.

Traceability

Links from each requirement to the backlog items or deliverables and the tests that cover it.

UAT (user acceptance testing)

Testing by the people who will use the product, to confirm it meets their needs.

User story

A short description of a need from the user's point of view: who, what and why.

Velocity

The amount of work a team finishes in one sprint, counted in the unit the team estimates in (such as story points), and counting only fully finished items. Teams use their recent average to plan how much to take on, and watch the trend for signs that they are speeding up or are blocked.

WBS (work breakdown structure)

A breakdown of the project scope into smaller deliverables and work packages.

WBS dictionary

A companion to the WBS that describes each work package: what it delivers, its acceptance criteria and who accepts it.

WCAG (Web Content Accessibility Guidelines)

The W3C standard for making web content usable by people with disabilities.

Work package

The lowest level of the WBS: a piece of work small enough to assign, estimate and track.

Appendix D. Sources & further reading

These works were consulted for ideas, coverage and background. No affiliation with, or endorsement by, their authors, publishers, PMI or Google is implied. Names are used only to identify the sources.

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Appendix E. Recovery plays by cause

Most projects drift off track at some point. This appendix lists common causes, the signs that point to each one, and a first response. It adds no new steps: each response points back to the steps and templates that already cover it.

E.1 Start with a health check

Before choosing a response, find out where the project really stands.

1. Baselines. Compare scope, schedule and budget with the approved baselines, and measure how far actual progress has moved from them.
2. Risks and issues. List the open Red and Amber items and who owns each one.
3. Sponsor. Is the sponsor engaged, and do they know the real position?
4. Goals. Do the original goals and success criteria still hold?

Then choose one of three paths: recover within the baselines, re-baseline through change control (Step 4.2), or escalate to the sponsor for a decision (Step 4.5). Never re-baseline silently. A changed baseline needs a logged decision.

E.2 Scope creep

- Signs: requests are being done without a change request; the team is adding small extras; the backlog grows with no matching change in dates or budget.
- First response: stop absorbing requests. Raise each one as a change (on a Change Request Form where the project uses one, otherwise through the Product Owner and the backlog), log it, and show its impact on schedule, cost and risk. Offer the sponsor three choices: approve it with the extra time or money, trade it for something already in scope, or defer it to a later phase. Remind everyone of the out-of-scope list in the charter.
- Where to look: Steps 1.5, 2.2 and 4.2.

E.3 Missed deadlines

- Signs: float is used up; milestones slip; tasks sit at 90% complete; velocity falls while scope stays the same.
- First response: re-forecast from actual progress, not from the original plan. Find the critical path and what is driving the slip. Then offer options: cut scope using the MoSCoW lines, add capacity only where it will help (new people need time before they are useful), or move the date through change control.
- Where to look: Steps 2.3, 4.1 and 4.5.

E.4 Changing requirements

- Signs: stories are rewritten again and again; people disagree about what done means; work is redone after review.
- First response: separate changes inside agreed scope (reordering the backlog, which needs no change request) from changes to scope, a milestone or the budget (which do). Confirm who approves each requirement and who accepts it, and review the acceptance criteria with that person. If the Definition of Done changes, log it as a decision.
- Where to look: Steps 2.1, 2.8, 4.2 and 4.4.

E.5 Over budget

- Signs: spend on a budget line is more than 10% over plan; the contingency reserve is falling faster than the work is finishing; nobody can say what it will cost to finish.
- First response: find which lines are over and why. Forecast the cost to finish from the work that remains, not from the original estimate. Then offer options: reduce scope, find savings, use the reserve as the plan allows, or ask the sponsor for more funding through change control.
- Where to look: Steps 2.4 and 4.1.

Earned value formulas (from the PMI method). Each term is spelled out with its abbreviation.

- PV (planned value): the budget for the work that should be finished by now. EV (earned value): the budget for the work actually finished. AC (actual cost): what has been spent so far. BAC (budget at completion): the total approved budget.
- SV (schedule variance) = EV − PV. A negative number means behind schedule.
- CV (cost variance) = EV − AC. A negative number means over budget.
- SPI (schedule performance index) = EV ÷ PV. Below 1.0 means behind schedule.
- CPI (cost performance index) = EV ÷ AC. Below 1.0 means the work is costing more than planned.
- EAC (estimate at completion) = BAC ÷ CPI, if the current cost performance will continue. Or EAC = AC + ETC, using a fresh bottom-up estimate of the remaining work. The Project Workbook uses the second method: it adds up each budget line’s actual cost and forecast to complete.
- ETC (estimate to complete) = EAC − AC: what it should cost to finish.
- VAC (variance at completion) = BAC − EAC. A negative number means the project is forecast to finish over budget.
- TCPI (to-complete performance index) = (BAC − EV) ÷ (BAC − AC): the cost performance needed from now on to finish within the budget. A number well above 1.0 means the budget is unlikely to hold.

E.6 Nobody knows what is left

- Signs: the schedule and backlog are out of date; different people give different answers; percent complete does not match what has been delivered.
- First response: rebuild the list of remaining work, split into done, in progress and not started. Give every item an owner and an estimate to finish. Check the done items against the Acceptance Log. Then re-forecast the date and the cost from that list.
- Where to look: Steps 2.2, 3.2, 4.1 and 4.4.

E.7 An overloaded or short-staffed team

- Signs: people are planned beyond 60 to 80% of their available time; overtime is routine; mistakes and rework are rising.
- First response: re-plan to a realistic load. Move work, add people or cut scope. Cross-train so that no task depends on one person. Do not ask the same people to catch up by working longer.
- Where to look: Steps 2.5, 3.1 and 3.2.

E.8 Quality or security failures

- Signs: defects or critical vulnerabilities are rising; tests fail late; items marked done do not meet the Definition of Done.
- First response: stop starting new work until the cause is understood. Fix and re-test, and check that the Definition of Done is being applied. Do not go live with a critical No on the readiness checklist unless the sponsor and the Security Lead record an exception.
- Where to look: Steps 3.3 and 4.4, and the go-live checklist (T22).

E.9 A vendor slipping

- Signs: a vendor misses a date, gives no firm date, or delivers work that fails acceptance.
- First response: get a firm date in writing and check what the contract (SOW) says about dates and remedies. Look for ways to keep moving: do other work first, build against a stub or sandbox, or ask for a partial delivery. Log the risk or issue, and escalate with options if a milestone will move.
- Where to look: Steps 3.6 and 4.3.

E.10 A sponsor who is not engaged

- Signs: decisions wait for weeks; meetings are missed; the sponsor hears about problems late.
- First response: find out why. Talk to the sponsor directly, not by email. Ask what is getting in the way: time, priorities, confidence in the project, or unclear role expectations.
- Where to look: Steps 1.3, 4.3 and 4.5.

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